

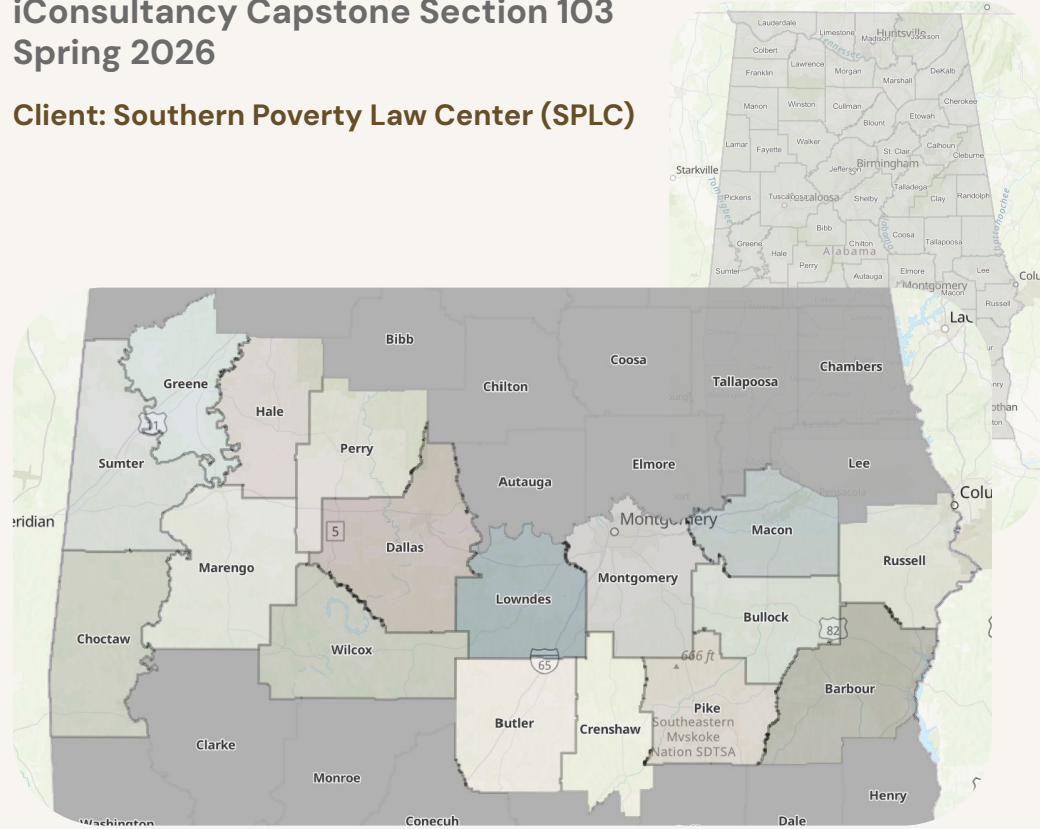
SPLC Alabama Counties

Voting & Civic Participation *Alabama Black Belt Counties*

A Regional Story in Data

College of Information, University of Maryland
iConsultancy Capstone Section 103
Spring 2026

Client: Southern Poverty Law Center (SPLC)



What We'll Cover

01

Overview

02

Data Foundation

03

The Picture That Emerged

04

Beyond the Ballot Box

05

From Data to Action

06

Conclusions & Recommendations

SECTION 01

Overview

Who Is the Southern Poverty Law Center?



What They Do

Founded in 1971, the Southern Poverty Law Center is a civil rights organization based in Montgomery, Alabama. They use litigation, advocacy, and education to fight hate, bigotry, and discrimination, with a particular focus on the American South.

How They Work

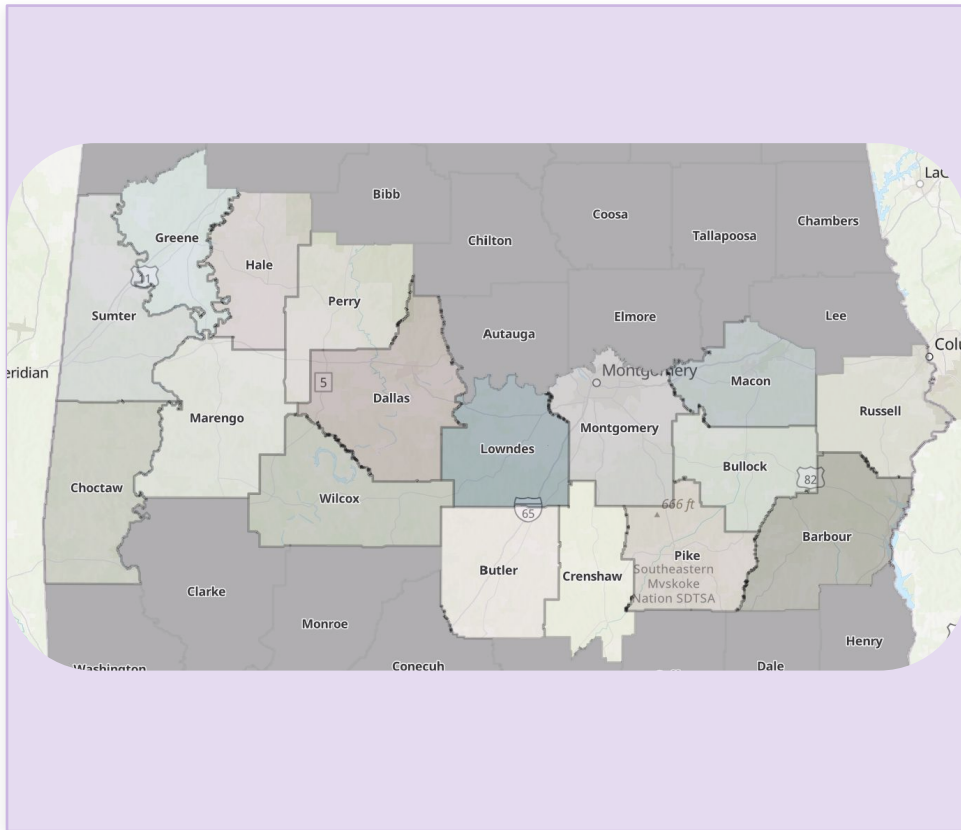
SPLC pursues impact through federal lawsuits, policy advocacy, community education, and intelligence research on extremist groups. Their legal work has produced landmark civil rights victories, and their monitoring programs track hate groups nationwide.

This Project's Goal

SPLC is interested in county-level data on civic participation barriers across Alabama's Black Belt, information that requires analysis and collaboration across multiple disconnected sources, to inform voter advocacy, legal strategy, and community outreach decisions.

Alabama & the Black Belt Counties

17 counties. A region defined by history, geography, and structural inequality.



17

Counties in Study

Black Belt region

~543,000

Total Population

Across study area

Largely rural

68% Rural
(excluding Montgomery County)

vs. AL average 42%

\$31,495 – \$58,153

Median Income

(ACS 2019–2023)

11 of 17 counties
majority-Black

% Black or African American

Regional average 56%

~416,000+

Registered Voters

2020 General Election

Alabama & the Black Belt Counties

17 counties. A region defined by history, geography, and structural inequality.

County	Percent of Population Rural	County	Percent of Population Rural
Barbour	65.92%	Macon	53.91%
Bullock	100.00%	Marengo	67.77%
Butler	69.43%	Montgomery	12.36%
Choctaw	100.00%	Perry	100.00%
Crenshaw	100.00%	Pike	56.18%
Dallas	44.86%	Russell	40.35%
Greene	100.00%	Sumter	100.00%
Hale	100.00%	Wilcox	100.00%
Lowndes	100.00%		

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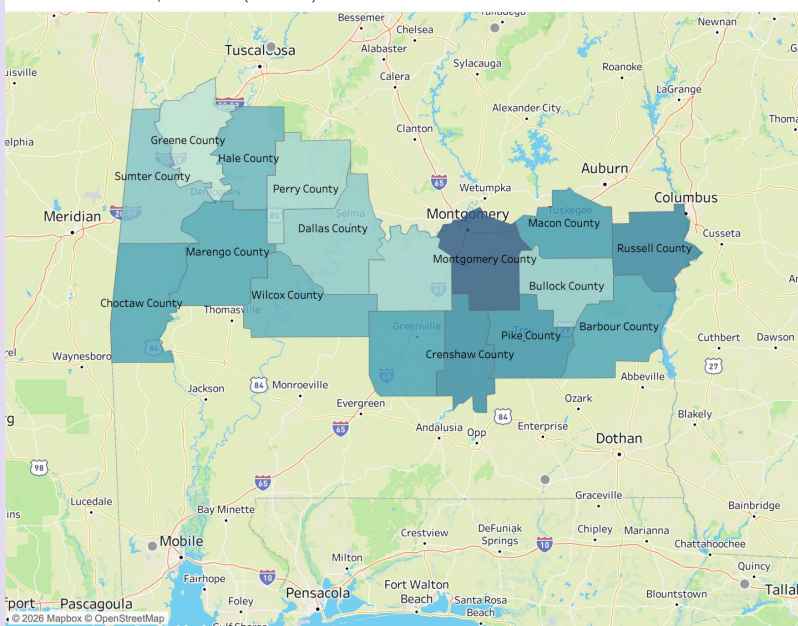
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Income and Transportation (Shuttle) Data



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2020 General Election

Hispanic & Latino Residents: A Small but Present Population

The Black Belt's Hispanic and Latino population is small, geographically concentrated, and growing statewide

Alabama's Hispanic population grew 42% between 2010 and 2020, accounting for nearly a third of the state's total population growth that decade—important context for longer-term regional work even where current numbers are thin

Scale

~18,000 Hispanic/Latino residents across the 17-county region—3.3% of the regional population, compared to 5.3% statewide and 18.7% nationwide

Concentration

Nearly 80% of the region's Hispanic residents live in just three counties: Montgomery, Russell, and Barbour

Interpretation Caution

In the remaining 14 counties, populations range from under 30 people (Greene) to just over 900 (Pike), making county-level percentage comparisons unreliable without underlying counts

SECTION 02

Data Foundation

The Data Landscape: What We Had to Work With

Before findings come methods. Here is the data that made this project possible—and the gaps we had to work around.

Voter Registration & Turnout

Teams: T1, T2

Alabama Secretary of State voter registration and election results by county; precinct-level data where available (2020 and 2024 general elections)

Census & ACS Data

Teams: T1, T9

American Community Survey 5-Year Estimates (2019–2023): demographics, income, car ownership, disability status, household composition by county

Geospatial/GIS

Teams: T1, T3, T4

Polling location coordinates, road network quality scores, transit route shapefiles, walking and driving distance calculations

Infrastructure Data

Teams: T4, T6

FCC National Broadband Map; Ookla speed test data (broadband index); public transit GTFS feeds; Uber/Lyft service area data

Accessibility Regs

Teams: T5

ADA Standards for Accessible Design; HAVA requirements; Google Earth visual audit of 49 polling locations in Montgomery County

Community Resources

Teams: T9, T11

Public library locations; food pantry and social service org databases; school locations; congregations data

Community Context & Personas: The People Behind the Data

Alabama's voting restrictions don't function as individual obstacles, they compound.



Danielle

The Overworked Caregiver

Wilcox county

Age: 30, Nursing Assistant

Barriers faced:

Works 12-hour shifts with no flexibility to leave for polls. No broadband at home—can't look up polling location online. No car; nearest neighbor with a vehicle works different hours. Wilcox County has no fixed-route transit.

Behavior towards voting:

Intends to vote but often misses the window due to time constraints



Carlos

The First-Generation Voter

Montgomery county

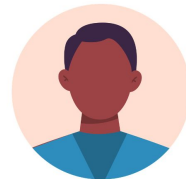
Age: 42, Manufacturing

Barriers faced:

Limited Spanish-language voting information available at his polling location. Required photo ID uses a name spelling different from his registration. Took unpaid time off to vote in 2020; couldn't afford to in 2024.

Behavior towards voting:

Politically interested but hesitates due to uncertainty and lack of clear guidance



Marcus

The Disengaged Young Adult

Russell county

Age: 22, Community College Student

Barriers faced:

First-time voter with no prior voting experience. Unsure of registration status after moving between counties. No early voting available in Alabama; class schedule conflicts with Election Day hours. Limited access to digital tools for registration lookup.

Behavior towards voting:

Says he'll vote but minor inconveniences (e.g., long lines, rain) deter him

Community Context & Personas: The People Behind the Data

Alabama's voting restrictions don't function as individual obstacles, they compound.



Evelyn
The Isolated Senior

Barbour county

Age: 76, Retired Construction Worker

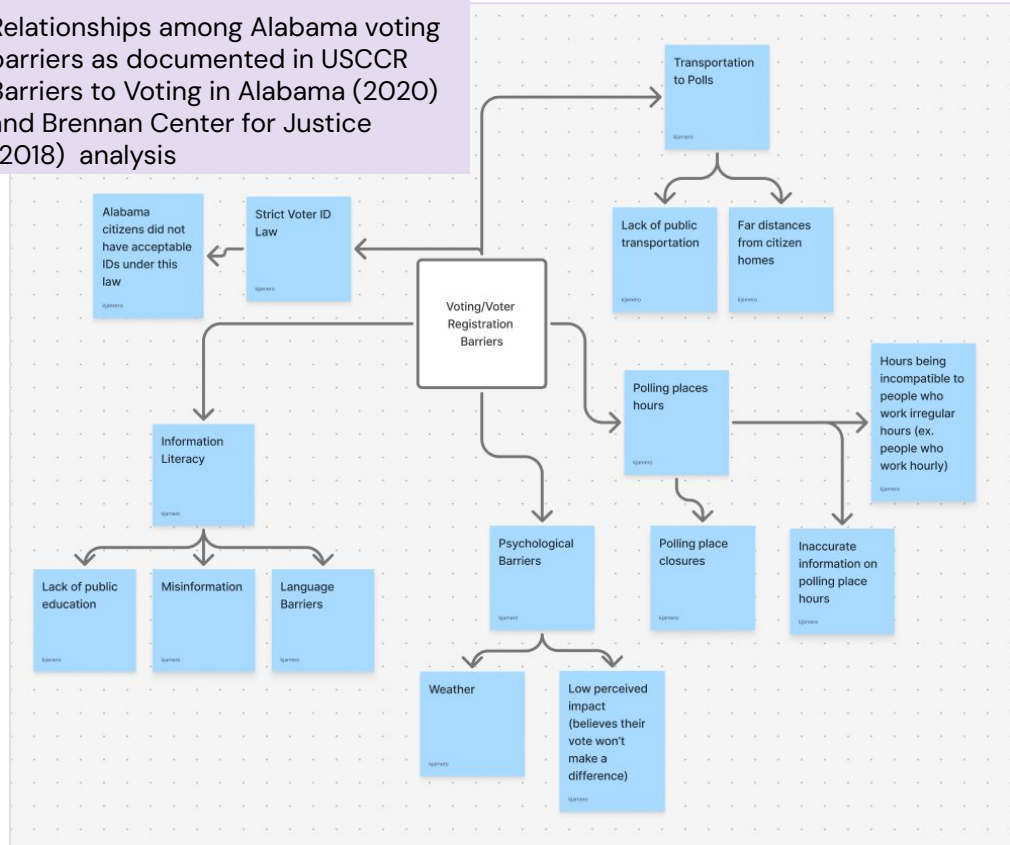
Barriers faced:

Has mobility issues from working construction before retirement; age has only exacerbated. No curbside voting at her precinct polling location and limited transportation options motivates her to look into absentee voting. The absentee voting ballot process is difficult.

Behavior towards voting:

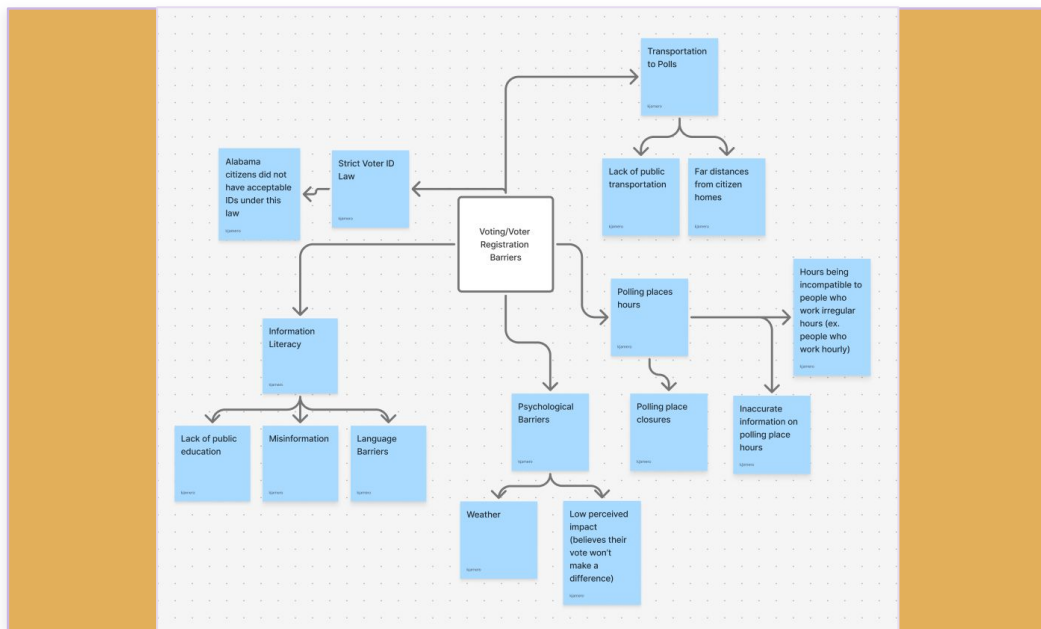
Previously consistent voter, but now rarely turns out due to physical barriers

Relationships among Alabama voting barriers as documented in USCCR Barriers to Voting in Alabama (2020) and Brennan Center for Justice (2018) analysis



Compounding Barriers: How Alabama's Voting Restrictions Interact

Alabama's voting restrictions do not function as individual obstacles—they compound. A voter without broadband cannot look up their polling location; a voter without a car cannot reach a polling place 10 miles away on roads that are 45% unmaintained; a worker on a 10-hour shift cannot leave during the only hours polls are open; and a first-time voter who moved counties must register 15 days in advance with no same-day option. The state's structural barriers are most acute for caregivers, hourly laborers, seniors, recent movers, and first-generation voters.



815,000

People from Alabama missing from elections—roughly 21% of the state's voting-age population

KEY TAKEAWAY

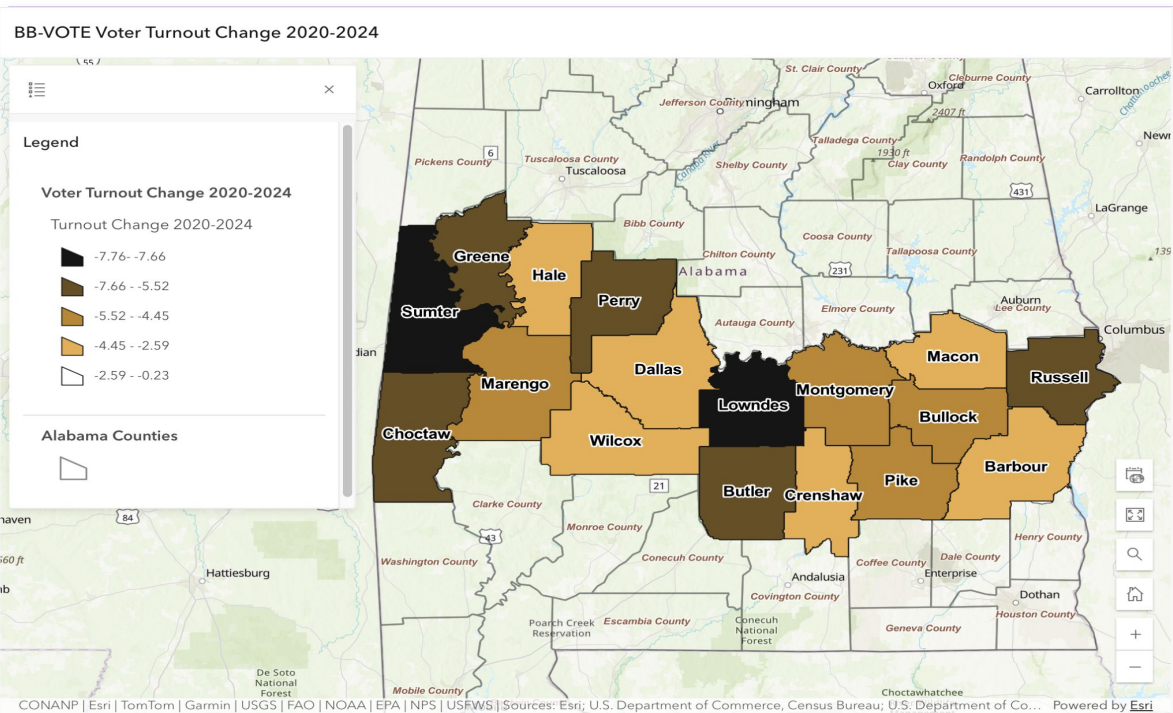
Alabama's overlapping restrictions—*excuse-required absentee balloting, strict photo ID, and a 15-day registration deadline with no same-day option*—mean missing any single step can mean not voting. Nearly 500,000 were removed from voter rolls in 2025 through routine list-maintenance. Statewide, 14.9% of Black voters carry inactive status vs. 12.7% of white voters. For the state's most vulnerable voters, every barrier has a cost.

SECTION 03

The Picture That Emerged

Voter Turnout: Who Shows Up, and Who Doesn't

Turnout fell in all 17 Black Belt counties between 2020 and 2024—a regional decline of nearly 5 percentage points, outpacing the Gulf Coast's 3.4-point drop



~23,000 (-9.2%)

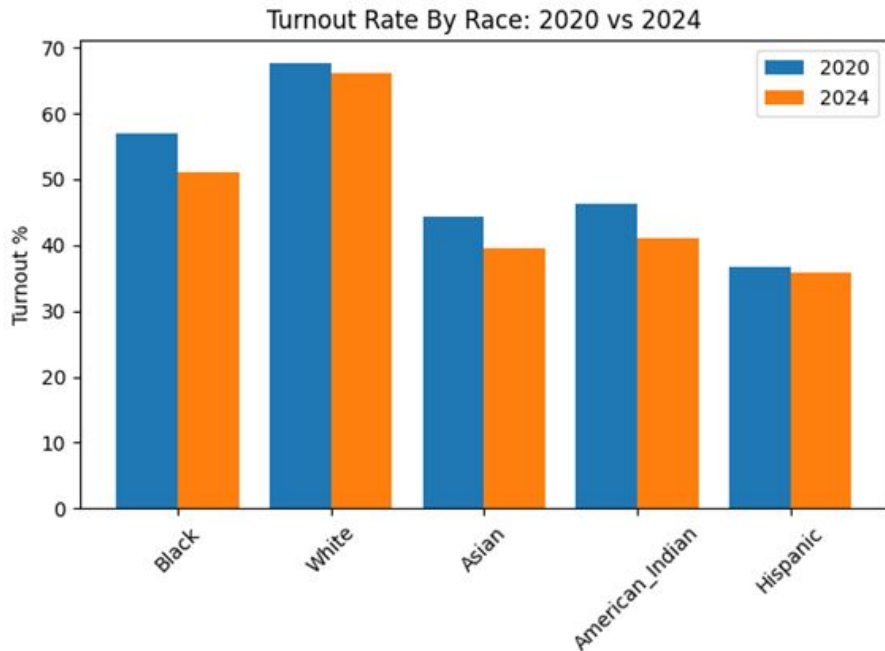
Fewer ballots cast in the Black Belt in 2024 than 2020, a drop from 248,335 to 225,537

KEY TAKEAWAY

Every Black Belt county saw turnout decline. The steepest drops—Sumter (-7.8pp), Lowndes (-7.7pp), Greene (-6.6pp)—are concentrated in the region's smallest, most rural, majority-Black counties. The Black Belt's overall decline exceeded the Gulf Coast's by 1.5 percentage points, suggesting structural access barriers beyond the national incumbent-effect pattern.

Voter Turnout: Who Shows Up, and Who Doesn't

Alabama's statewide Black voter turnout rate fell from 56.8% to 51.9% between 2020 and 2024—while the white-Black participation gap reached a 16-year high



~51,000 (-9.1%)

Fewer Black ballots cast statewide in 2024 than 2020, despite the Black voting-eligible population remaining essentially unchanged at roughly 985,000 eligible voters

KEY TAKEAWAY

Black voter participation declined in 21 of 24 study counties (in Black Belt and Gulf Coast). Hispanic ballots cast increased in absolute numbers—but the eligible Hispanic population grew faster, leaving the turnout rate essentially flat at roughly 19%.

Voter Turnout: Who Shows Up, and Who Doesn't

Turnout Fell Preferences Didn't

Correlation between Black voter percentage and Democratic vote share was nearly identical in 2020 ($r = 0.99$) & 2024 ($r = 0.99$). The structural relationship between race and vote choice held constant. *What changed was how many eligible Black voters showed up—not how they voted when they did.*

A Clear Threshold—and One Exception

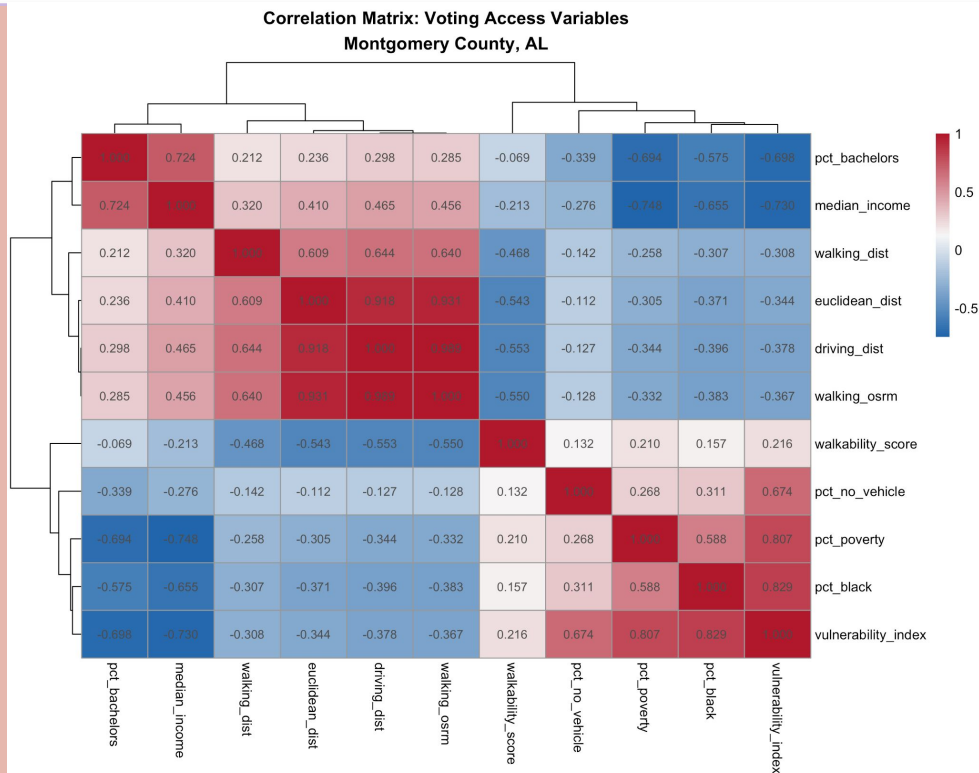
Across all three election cycles, counties above roughly 40–45% Black population voted consistently Democratic; those below voted consistently Republican—**without exception**. Montgomery County was the only major Black Belt county where Black voter participation increased from 2020 to 2024, adding 403 ballots. In a region defined by decline, Montgomery's stability is a proof of concept: **sustained participation is possible where infrastructure and outreach exist.**

Where It Mattered Most: Russell County & CD-2 Race

The 2024 2nd Congressional District race, made possible by the Supreme Court's *Allen v. Milligan* decision, demonstrated exactly what's at risk when Black turnout declines. ***Shomari Figures won, but Russell County, the most competitive county in the district, was decided by fewer than 400 votes in straight-party totals.*** A 5.5 percentage point turnout drop in Russell alone represents hundreds of ballots that didn't get cast. *The structural relationship between Black voter participation and Democratic representation is not abstract—in CD-2, it was the margin.*

Polling Access: Distance Is Not Equally Distributed

Average distance to polling places ranges from 1.02 to 1.58 miles depending on measurement method, but only 45.2% of routes are documented as maintained, meaning physical distance understates the real barrier



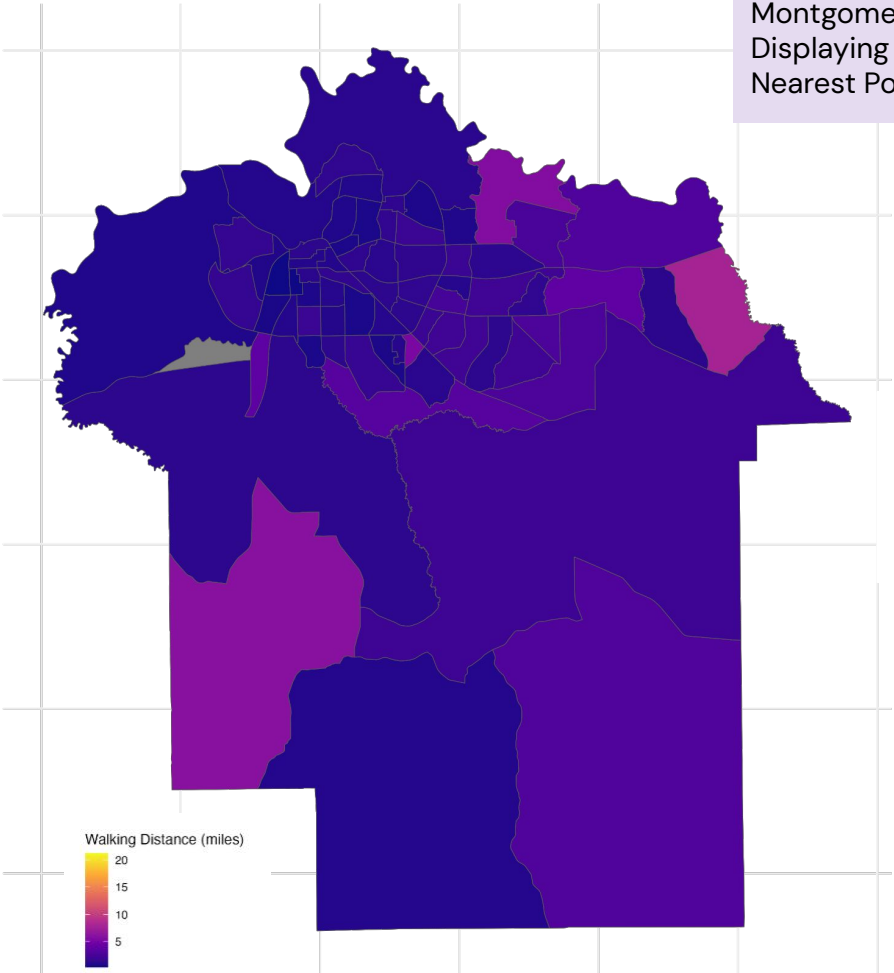
45.2%

Of routes to polling places documented as maintained
(road quality score: 54.6/100)

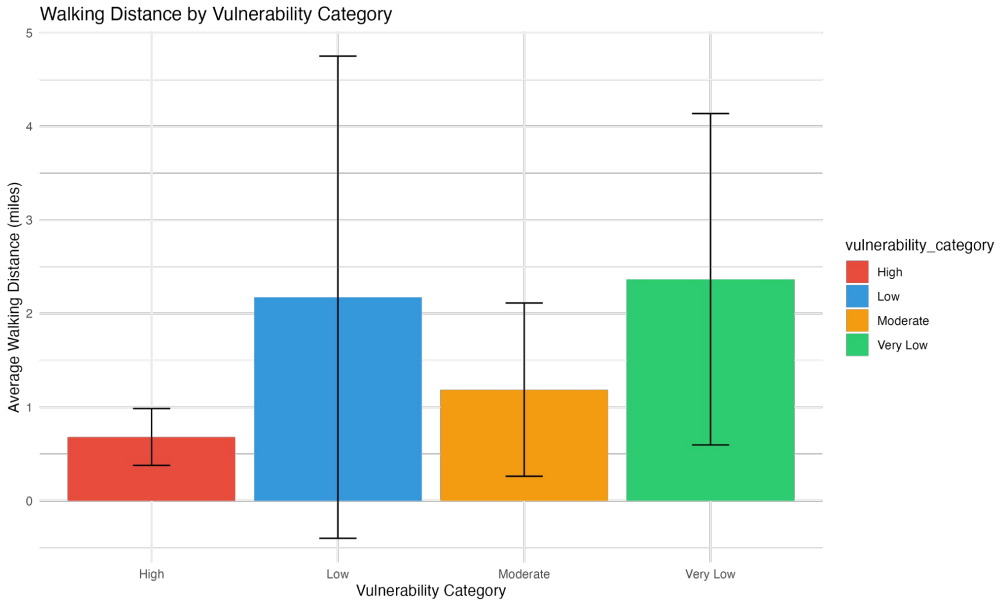
KEY TAKEAWAY

Higher-vulnerability, majority-POC urban areas show shorter distances on average, but rural areas face greater infrastructure barriers. **28% of block groups have poor or very poor polling accessibility.** SPLC can use T3's ArcGIS tool to identify specific neighborhoods where physical access is weakest and to target advocacy for infrastructure improvements.

Montgomery County, AL Choropleth Map
Displaying Walking Distances to the
Nearest Polling Places in each Tract



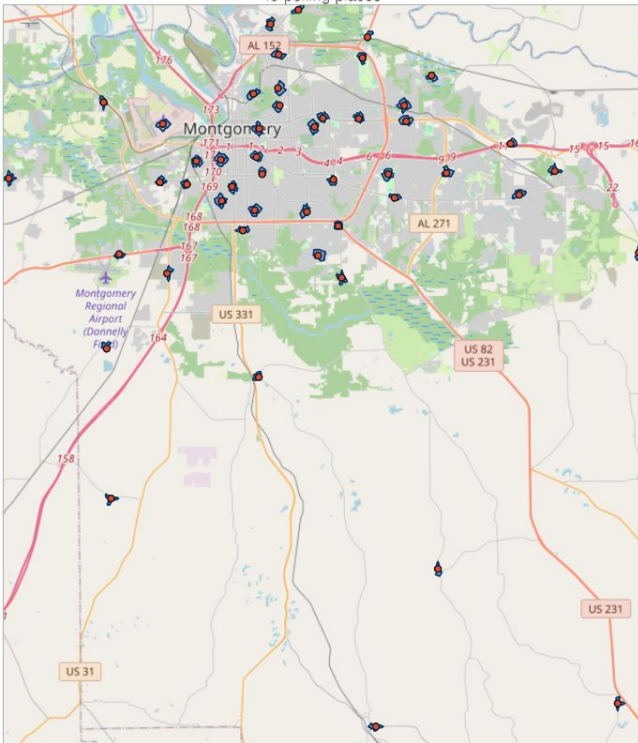
Montgomery County, AL Average Walking
Distance vs Vulnerability Category Bar Chart



Isochrone Maps for Population Centers that are within 5, 10, 15, 20, and 30-Minute Walking Distances of a Polling Place in Montgomery, AL): Zones showing how far you can walk (blue zones) from a polling location (red dot) within a given time period—used here to map how many voters fall within a 10, 20, or 30-minute walk of their polling place

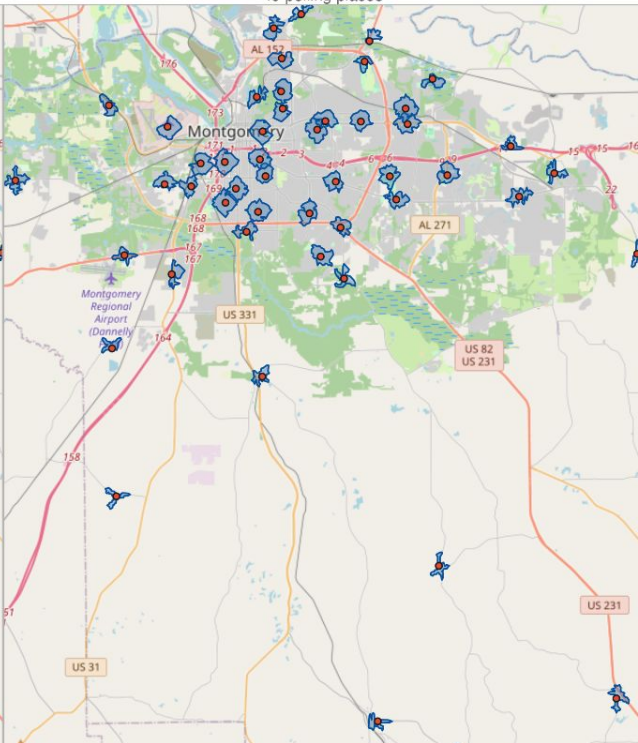
5 -Minute Walk

49 polling places



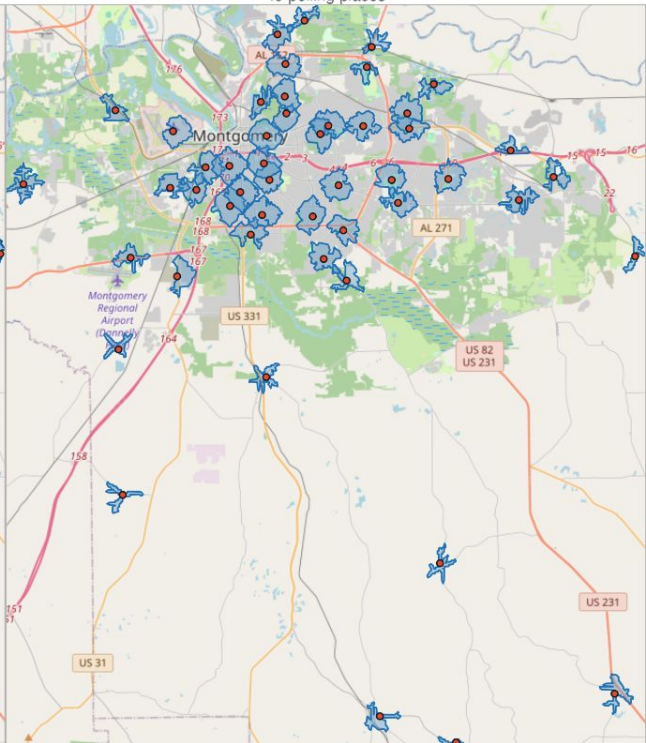
10 -Minute Walk

49 polling places



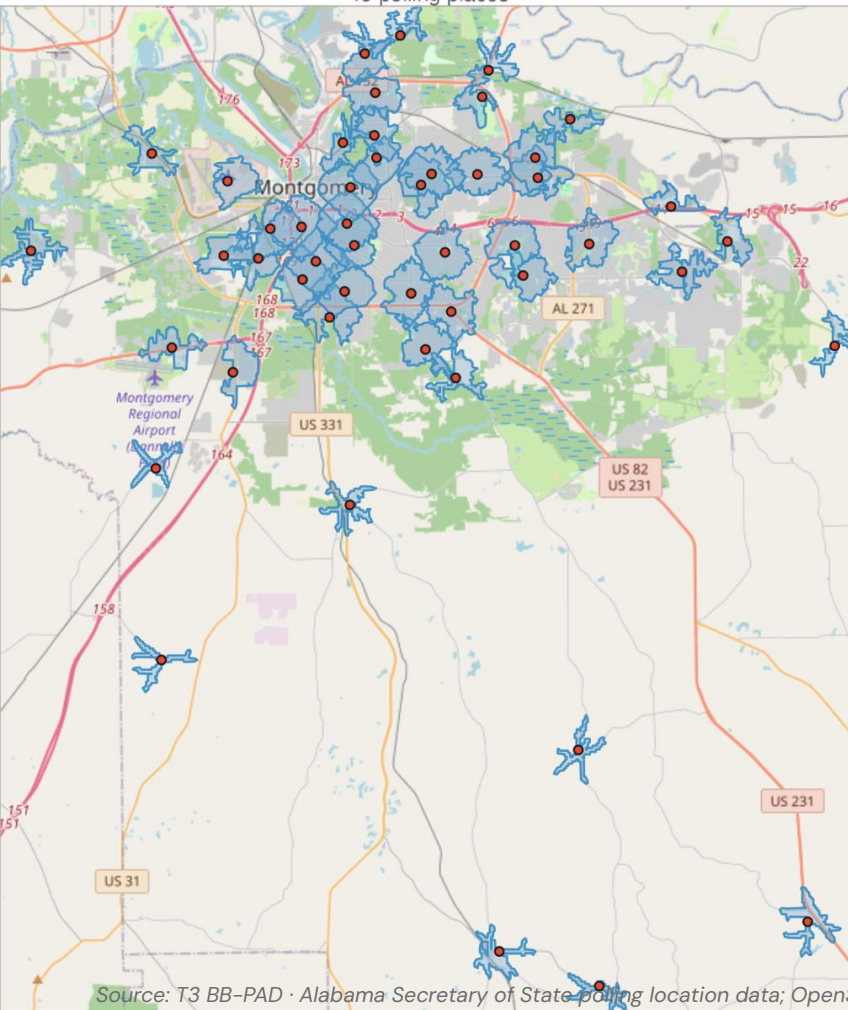
15 -Minute Walk

49 polling places



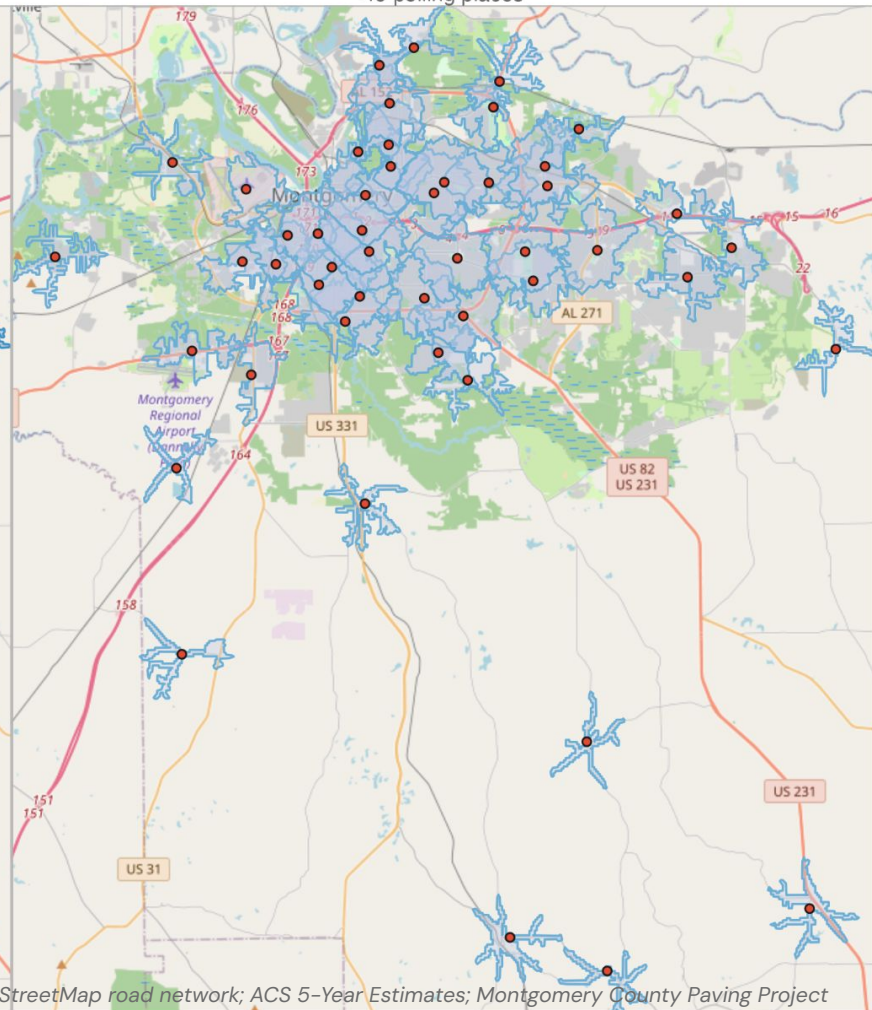
20 -Minute Walk

49 polling places



30 -Minute Walk

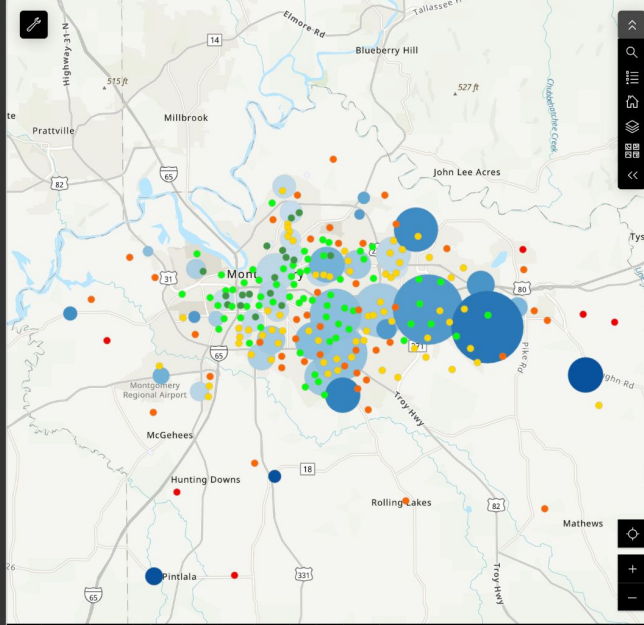
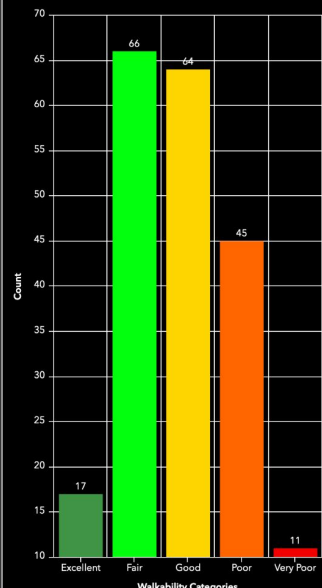
49 polling places



Source: T3 BB-PAD · Alabama Secretary of State polling location data; OpenStreetMap road network; ACS 5-Year Estimates; Montgomery County Paving Project

ArcGIS Montgomery County Distance and Polling Access Dashboard

[ArcGIS Dashboard](#)



GEOID	11,010,002,002
Latitude	32.37
Longitude	-86.32
Walking Distance to Nearest Polling Place (Miles)	0.79

Excellent -> Very Poor Accessibility

- Excellent
- Good
- Fair
- Poor
- Very Poor

Polling Place	Newtown Community Center
Address	1765 N. Decatur St.
Average Walking Distance From Population Centers (Miles)	0.21
Population	1

Source: T3 BB-PAD Alabama Secretary of State polling location data; OpenStreetMap road network; ACS 5-Year Estimates; Montgomery County Paving Project



Racial Justice Issues ▾

Find Resources ▾

State Support ▾



Check Your Voting Access:

Enter your address to see how easy it is to vote in your area

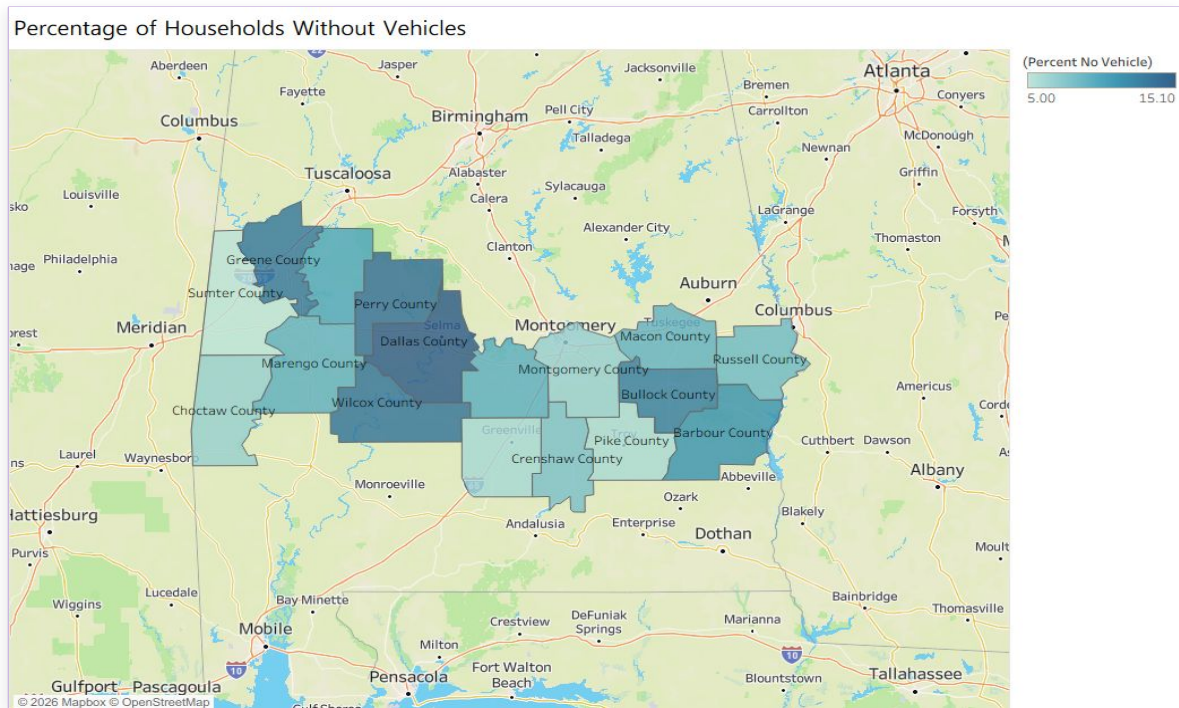
▼ Address or Zip Code

See My Score

We do not store your data

Transportation Barriers: Getting There Is the Problem

Dallas County has the highest car-free household rate in the region at 15.1%—and only advance-scheduled demand-response transit available. Bullock County has no transit at all.



15.1%

Households without a vehicle in Dallas County, highest in the region. 5 of 6 lowest-income counties have no fixed-route transit.

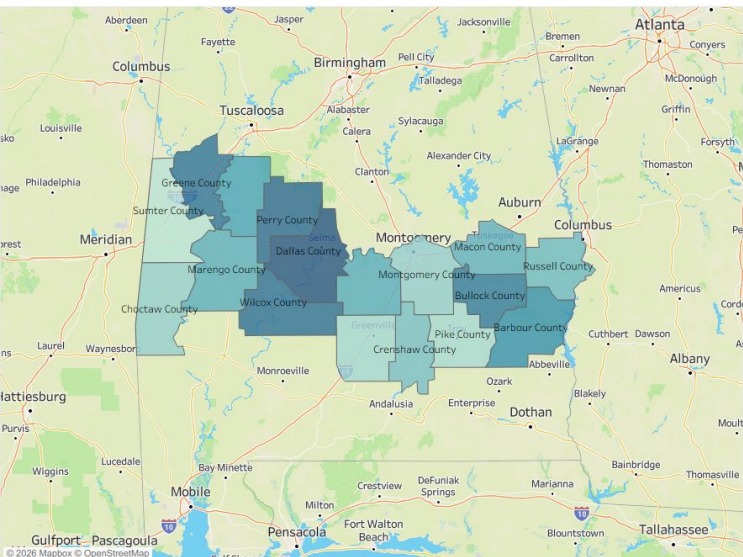
KEY TAKEAWAY

Bullock County: no transit service, 12.6% car-free households, nearly half of voters aged 60+, fourth-lowest median income in the region. Dallas County: 15.1% car-free, median income \$36,810, demand-response transit only (must call ahead to schedule). These two counties are the clearest first-tier targets for Election Day transportation resource deployment.

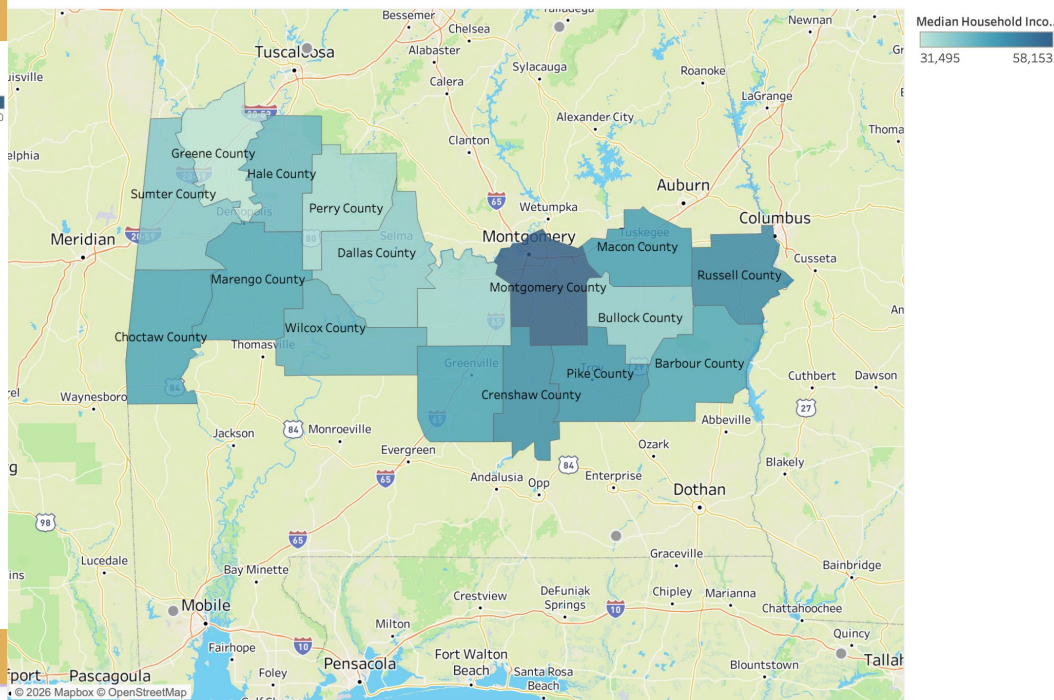
Vehicle Access Across the Black Belt

Five of the six lowest-income counties have no fixed-route transit. Bullock County has no transit at all.

Percentage of Households Without Vehicles

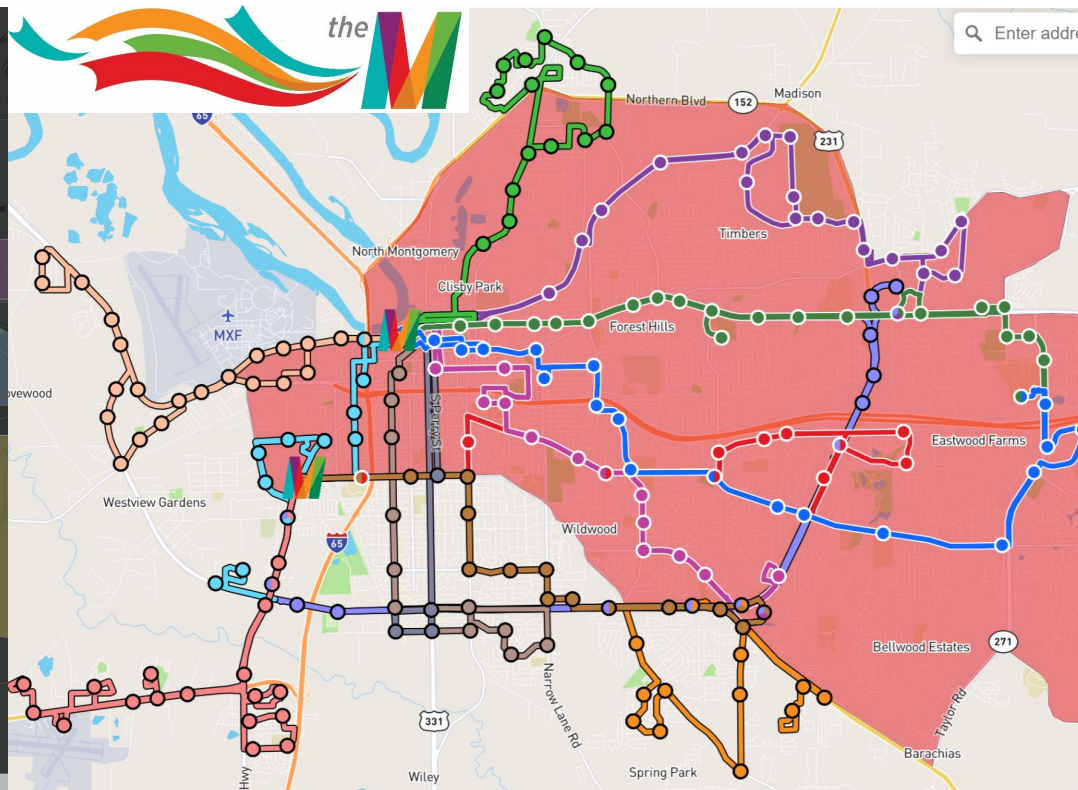


Income and Transportation (Shuttle) Data



Map based on Longitude (generated) and Latitude (generated). For marks layer County: Color shows sum of Median Household Income (2019–2023). The marks are labeled by County. Details are shown for various dimensions. For marks layer County Seat: Details are shown for County Seat.

Montgomery operates the region's only fixed-route bus system—14 routes, city limits only, no Sunday service—while the rest of the Black Belt depends on advance-scheduled demand-response transit and roads that may not be maintained.



26

What Gets Paved, and When, May Not Be Neutral

Montgomery's The M is the only fixed-route bus system in the Black Belt region—the rest of the region relies on demand-response services that require advance scheduling, creating a de facto barrier for spontaneous or same-day Election Day trips to the polls.

Montgomery's transit map and paving data together illustrate a compounding access problem. Bus routes end at city limits, leaving rural voters without fixed-route options. Within the city, road maintenance is prioritized by traffic volume and call volume—criteria that concentrate improvement in higher-traffic areas. The 45.2% of routes to polling places documented as maintained in T3's analysis reflects this backlog directly. For voters without cars in poorly maintained residential areas outside transit coverage, the barrier is not distance alone—it is the condition of the path.

19.2 miles

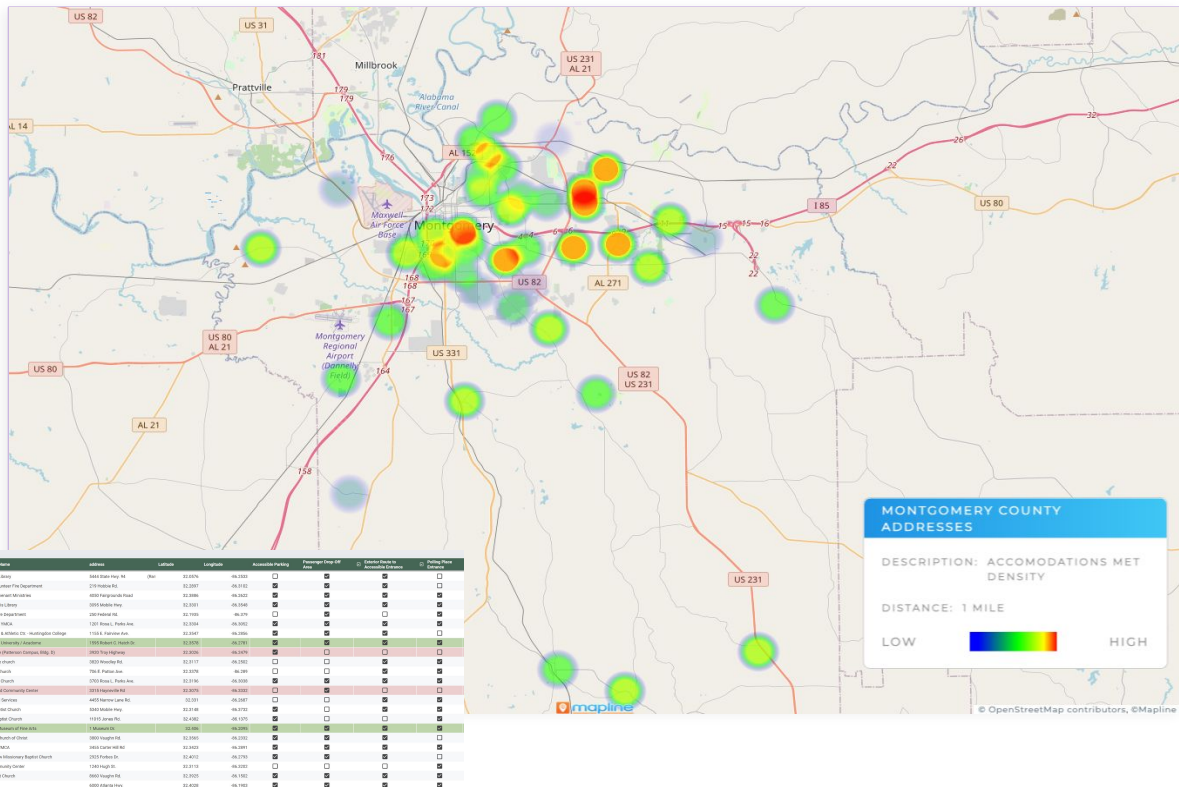
Of planned paving still remaining in Montgomery's FY2026 plan—funded through monthly Rebuild Alabama gas tax distributions that are *restricted by law to roads and bridges, with no allocation for transit or pedestrian infrastructure*

OPEN RESEARCH QUESTIONS

Are road maintenance projects in Montgomery *deferred disproportionately* in lower-income and majority-Black neighborhoods? And in election years specifically, are the routes between those neighborhoods and their assigned polling places among those *left unaddressed*? Does active road construction cluster on routes between majority-Black neighborhoods and their polling places *in the weeks before an election*—and if so, is that pattern consistent enough across election cycles to warrant litigation scrutiny?

Accessibility: The Gap Is at the Door

Across 49 Montgomery County polling locations, accessible parking and exterior routes are common—but accessible entrances are not. Only 35% of locations clear all four critical access criteria simultaneously.



7 of 49

Polling locations meeting all six ADA criteria—just 14% of surveyed sites. 14 locations meet three or fewer, meaning **nearly 1 in 3 Montgomery County polling places has multiple simultaneous access failures for voters with disabilities.**

KEY TAKEAWAY

Physical entry barriers are the most common gap, more prevalent than parking or exterior access issues. SPLC can use T5's deliverables to identify which specific Montgomery County locations fail ADA requirements, prioritize those sites for improvement advocacy, and recommend fully compliant locations to voters with mobility needs ahead of upcoming elections.

How We Looked: A Virtual Audit of 49 Polling Places

Each of the 49 Montgomery County polling locations was assessed using Google Earth and Street View imagery against the U.S. Department of Justice ADA Checklist for Polling Places—six criteria, evaluated consistently across all sites by assigned team members.

Evaluation Criteria

1. Accessible Parking
2. Passenger Drop-Off Area
3. Exterior Route to Accessible Entrance
4. Polling Place Entrance
5. Ramps
6. Elevators/One Floor



Montgomery Museum of Fine Arts (Precinct 103)

APPEARS COMPLIANT

Clearly marked accessible parking, level exterior route, accessible entrance confirmed visually.

Hayneville Road Community Center (Precinct 203)

APPEARS NON-COMPLIANT

Met 1 of 6 criteria. No accessible parking, no drop-off area, entrance not confirmable as accessible.



A Gap No One Is Required to Close

There is no mandatory federal requirement for pre-election physical accessibility audits of polling places.

The DOJ monitors whether accessible voting equipment is present—but *does not systematically assess* whether voters with disabilities can actually reach it. Enforcement is **primarily complaint-driven**, meaning most accessibility failures are discovered by voters who cannot enter on Election Day.

In Alabama, counties only conducted ADA compliance audits of polling places in 2024 after civil rights advocates forced the issue and even then, *no centralized statewide list of polling locations existed six months before the primary election* (ACLU of Alabama, 2025).

T5's virtual audit of all 49 Montgomery County polling locations is, to the team's knowledge, the first systematic accessibility assessment of these sites. It is a starting point, not a conclusion.

Priority Locations

Location	Address	Criteria Met
Trenholm State (Patterson Campus)	3920 Troy Hwy	1 of 6
Hayneville Road Community Center	3315 Hayneville Rd	1 of 6
Union Chapel AME Church	3100 Old Wetumpka Hwy	1 of 6
Catholic Social Services	4455 Narrow Lane Rd	2 of 6
McIntyre Community Center	1240 Hugh St	2 of 6

Closing the Accessibility Gap: Better Data, Active Litigation

Alabama SB1 | Still in Litigation

Alabama's SB1 made it a felony to help a voter with an absentee ballot application, even for paid caregivers assisting people with disabilities.

A federal court blocked enforcement for the 2024 election, finding the law violated voters' right to choose who helps them vote (Section 208 of the Voting Rights Act). SPLC was part of the coalition that won that ruling. The state appealed; the case is still active as of this presentation.

For voters with disabilities who cannot reach an inaccessible polling place, absentee voting is often the only alternative—making SB1's restrictions on assisted absentee applications a direct extension of the physical access failures T5 documented.

In-Person Physical Audit

The DOJ's ADA Checklist for Polling Places is a public federal tool designed for exactly this purpose—roughly 30 minutes per site with a trained assessor, producing documentation usable in advocacy and litigation. No Alabama county is currently required to complete one before designating a polling place.

Election Day Reporting

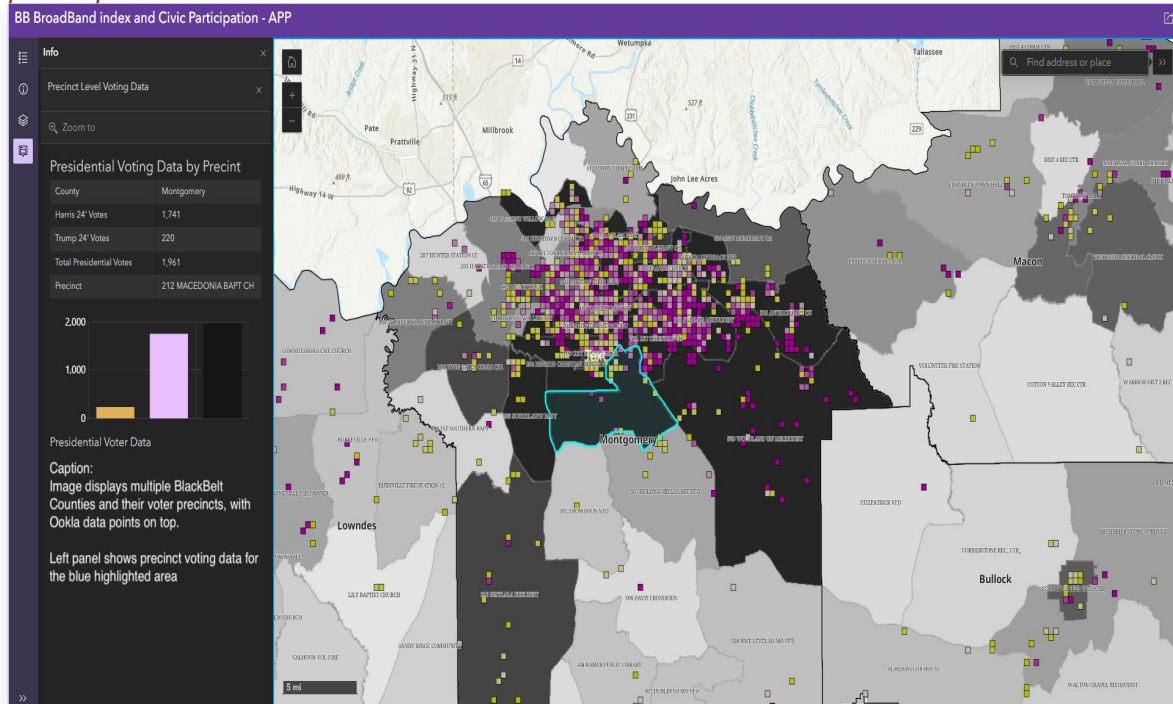
In 2024, the Alabama Election Protection Coalition logged accessibility barriers in real time, which directly triggered county-level ADA audits. Reactive by design, but it works and it produced the only known systematic accessibility review in Alabama's recent history.

Virtual Audit (T5's Method)

Scalable and low-cost as a first screen, using Google Earth and Street View against the federal ADA checklist. Not sufficient for litigation on its own, but enough to identify priority sites for in-person follow-up—which is precisely what T5's dataset makes possible.

Broadband Access: The Digital Divide in Civic Participation

Voting precincts with stronger broadband performance, higher speed test volume and index scores above 100, showed higher voter turnout in the 2024 presidential election. Where broadband is absent, the basic digital infrastructure of civic participation is too.



100

The federal broadband standard score—download speeds of 100 Mbps/upload 20 Mbps. Precincts falling below this threshold lack reliable access to online voter registration, absentee ballot requests, and polling location lookup.

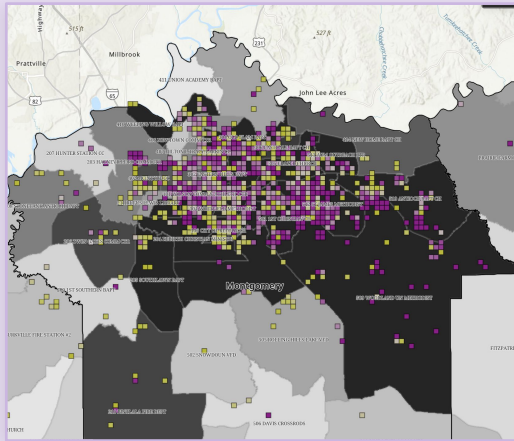
KEY TAKEAWAY

The correlation between broadband and turnout is real but not absolute—outliers exist in both directions. This is a proof of concept based on one election cycle. SPLC can use the interactive dashboard to identify hotspots where broadband gaps and low participation overlap, and to build the case for broadband infrastructure as a voting rights investment.

Broadband Access: What the Outliers Reveal

When Fast Internet Isn't Enough

Some precincts reported broadband index scores well above standard—including connections at 1 Gbps—yet still showed low voter turnout. The inverse is also true. Broadband access is a necessary condition for digital civic participation, but not a sufficient one.



High Broadband, Low Turnout

Where fast connections exist but participation is low, other barriers are doing the work—transportation, registration gaps, polling access, or the compounding structural barriers documented across this project.

Low Broadband, High Turnout

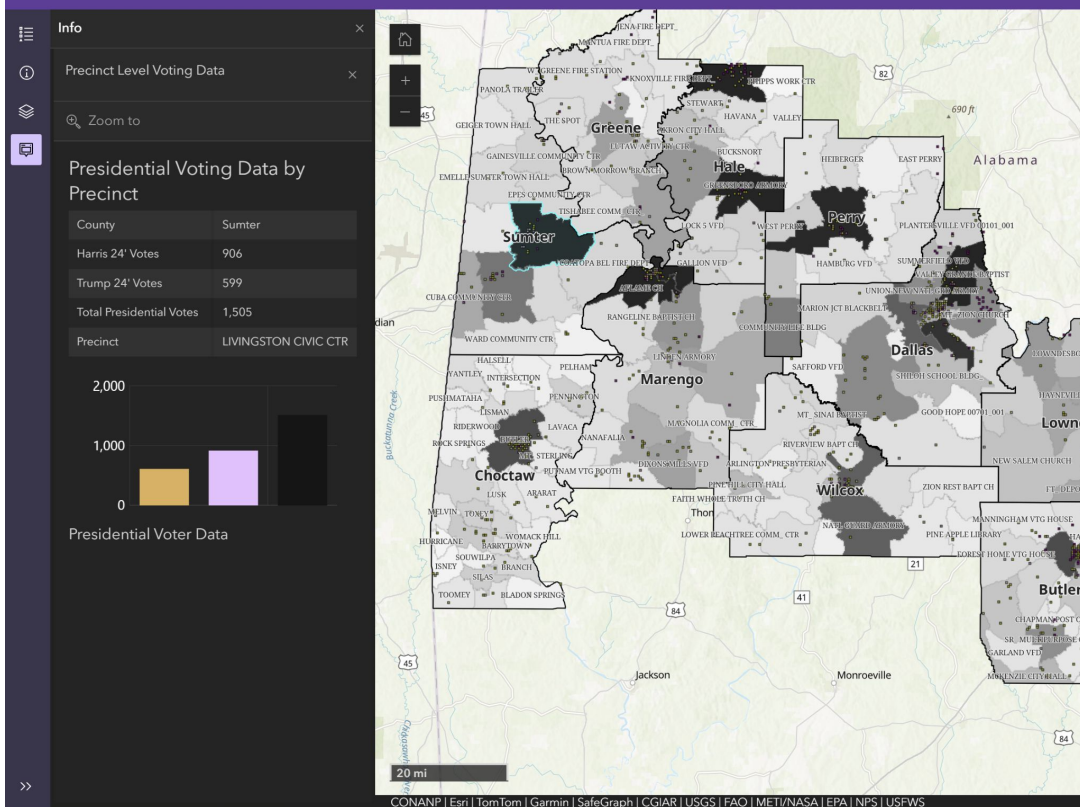
Where participation holds despite poor connectivity, community infrastructure—churches, libraries, civic organizations—may be compensating for the digital gap. These are the resilience patterns worth understanding.

The Proof of Concept

This analysis covers one election and one region. Its value to SPLC is as a framework: the methodology is replicable, the dashboard is expandable, and the broadband–turnout relationship is worth tracking across future election cycles as a leading indicator of access risk.

Explore the Data: Black Belt Broadband & Voter Turnout

BB BroadBand index and Civic Participation - APP



LIVE DASHBOARD

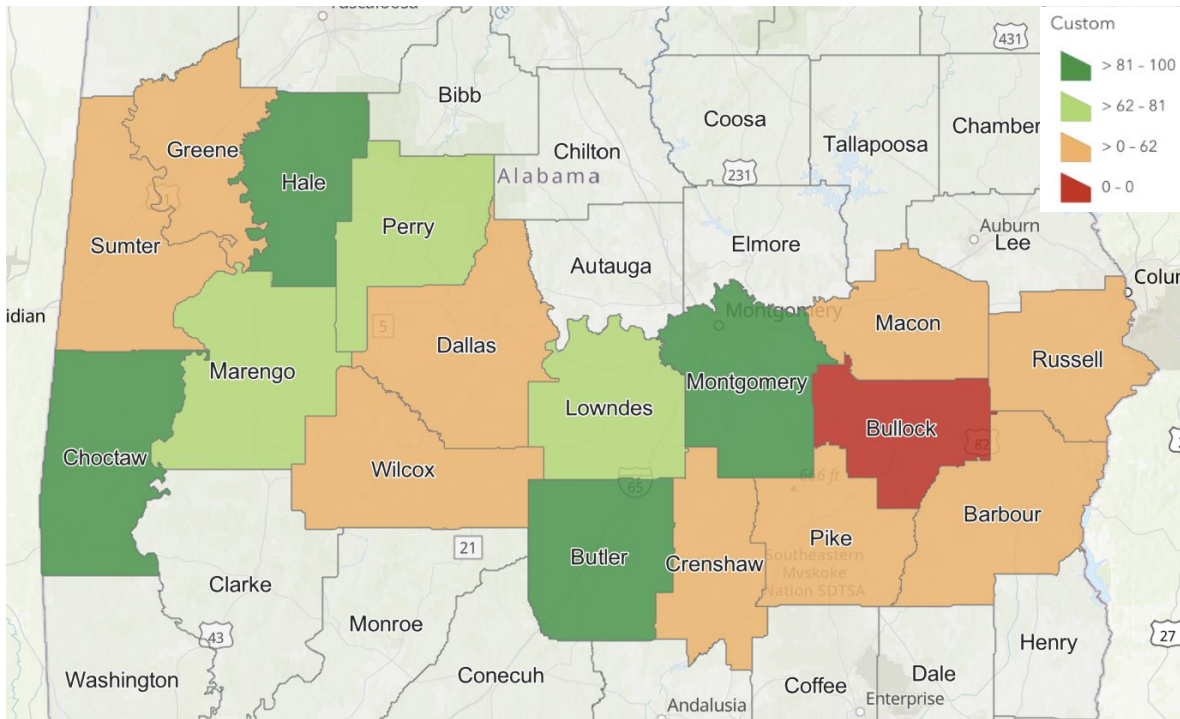
[ArcGIS Dashboard Link](#)

Purple tiles meet or exceed the federal broadband standard. Gold tiles fall below it. Precinct shading indicates 2024 voter turnout—darker means more ballots cast.

Click any tile or precinct to explore the underlying data.

Composite Civic Participation Risk Index: Where Barriers Converge

Seventeen variables across 17 counties, synthesized into a single county-level risk score using principal component analysis, factor analysis, and ArcGIS. Four subindices explain 73% of the variance in the underlying data.



Index Components

Infrastructure Access — 38%

Broadband, transit, libraries, education, disability

Demographic Variables — 30%

Age, gender, race turnout disparity

Geographic Isolation — 16%

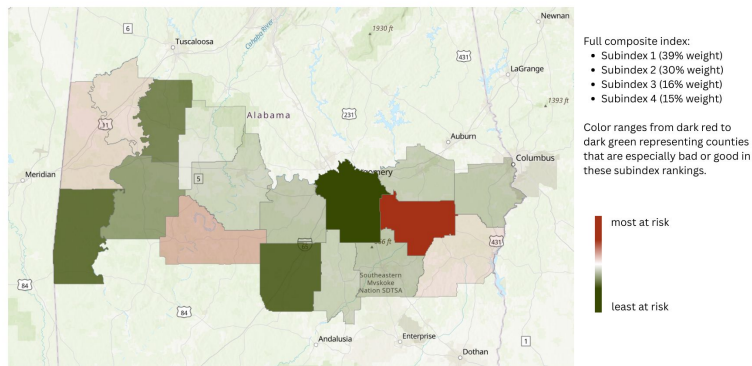
Rurality, polling distance, congregations, community colleges

Individual Capability — 14%

Language access, vehicle ownership, health status

Composite Civic Participation Risk Index: Where Barriers Converge

Seventeen variables across 17 counties, synthesized into a single county-level risk score using principal component analysis, factor analysis, and ArcGIS. Four subindices explain 73% of the variance in the underlying data.



Wilcox — Most at risk

Scored 0.00 on the composite index—the lowest in the region across all four subindices combined. Infrastructure access, demographic factors, geographic isolation, and individual capability all converge at their worst here.

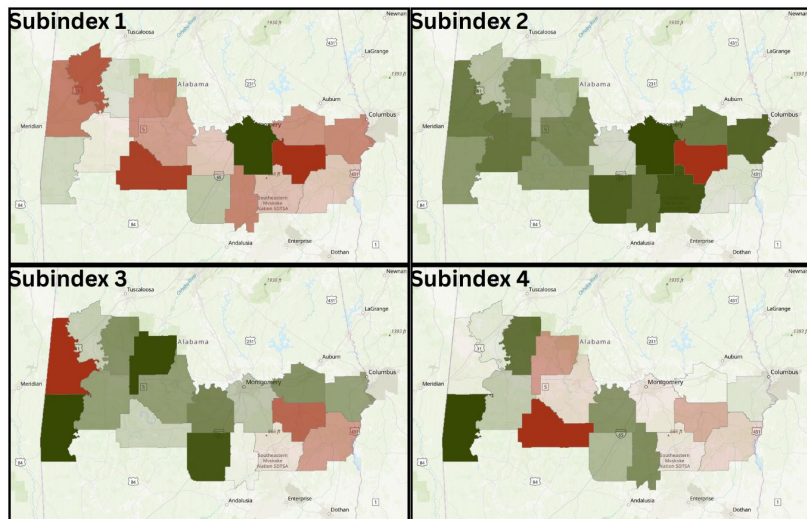
Butler — Least at risk

Scored 100—the highest in the region. A counterintuitive finding given Butler's modest size, worth exploring against SPLC's on-the-ground knowledge.

Montgomery — Second least at risk (94.42)

Ranks near the top overall despite scoring poorly on Subindex 4—individual capability factors including language access, vehicle ownership, and self-reported health. Population size and infrastructure advantages outweigh those gaps in the composite score.

Under the Hood: Four Lenses on Risk



most at risk

Color ranges from dark red to dark green representing counties that are especially bad or good in these subindex rankings.

least at risk

01 Subindex 1 — Infrastructure Access (38% weight)

Broadband, fixed transit, libraries, disability rate, education level. The highest-weighted subindex because infrastructure determines whether other forms of access are even possible.

03 Subindex 3 — Geographic Isolation (16% weight)

Rurality ranking, nearest polling place distance, congregations per capita, community colleges per capita. The community resources variables load here because in rural counties, civic institutions are often the only infrastructure connecting residents to participation.

02 Subindex 2 — Demographic Variables (30% weight)

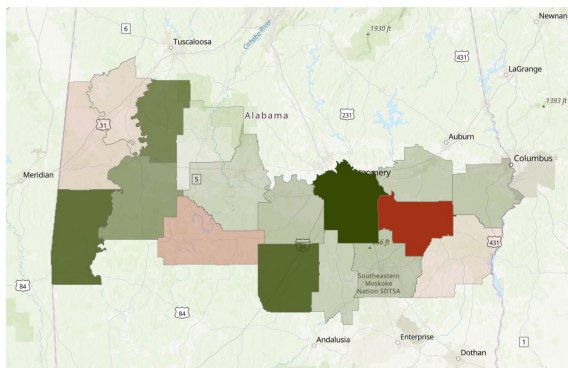
Age (seniors 65+), gender imbalance, race turnout disparity. The racial turnout disparity variable—pairwise gap between racial groups—loads heavily here and is among the most direct measures of structural inequity in the dataset.

04 Subindex 4 — Individual Capability (14% weight)

Non-English speakers, registered vehicles per capita, average physically unhealthy days. The lowest-weighted subindex—but the one that explains Montgomery's vulnerability despite its overall strong score.

A Decision Tool, Not a Verdict

The BB-CPRI is designed for pattern recognition, county prioritization, and advocacy planning—not as a definitive ranking of civic participation barriers. It is a starting point for SPLC's investigation, not a conclusion.



Full composite index:
• Subindex 1 (39% weight)
• Subindex 2 (30% weight)
• Subindex 3 (16% weight)
• Subindex 4 (15% weight)

Color ranges from dark red to dark green representing counties that are especially bad or good in these subindex rankings.

most at risk
least at risk

Use the index to prioritize

Counties scoring poorly across multiple subindices—not just the composite—are the clearest targets for resource allocation. ***Wilcox appears at or near the bottom across several subindices simultaneously.*** That convergence is the signal.

Use the subindices to diagnose

A county's composite score doesn't tell you why it's at risk. *The subindices do.* A county that scores poorly on Subindex 1 (infrastructure) needs different interventions than one that scores poorly on Subindex 4 (individual capability). The tool is designed to support that distinction.

Use the data knowing its limits

The index is built primarily on 2020 data—current conditions in some counties may have changed. The factor analysis sampling adequacy was low (KMO=0.27), meaning some variable relationships may not fully reflect underlying structural factors. *Future index updates with 2024 data and additional variables would strengthen the tool significantly.*

SECTION 04

Beyond the Ballot Box: ***What Civic Access Actually Requires***

Voting Rights and the Invisible Barriers

The legal framework for voting rights focuses on what the law *permits* or *prohibits*. This project focuses on something different: **the physical, infrastructural, and informational conditions that determine whether a legally eligible voter can actually cast a ballot.** These conditions don't appear in statutes. They don't require intent to suppress. But they function as barriers just as effectively as any law—and in Alabama's Black Belt, they cluster in the same communities, in the same counties, year after year.

The Legal Frame

ID requirements, registration deadlines, district maps, felon disenfranchisement. Visible, litigable, documented

The Infrastructural Frame

Road quality, transit access, broadband gaps, ADA non-compliance, polling place distance. Rarely litigated. Rarely even counted

The Reframe

Eleven teams spent a semester documenting the second category at county level, precinct level, and polling place level. The data exists now. The question is what to do next

The Same Person, Multiple Barriers

One Voter. Several Systems. One Outcome.



Danielle

The Overworked Caregiver

Wilcox county

Age: 30, Nursing Assistant

Works 12-hour shifts with no flexibility. No broadband at home, no car, no transit route. Wilcox County has the second-highest civic participation risk score in the region. Her barriers aren't legal—no law prevents her from voting. The systems around her do.

Multiple Barriers:

T4 transit gap, T6 broadband gap, T2 turnout decline, T3 polling distance



Evelyn

The Isolated Senior

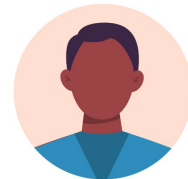
Barbour county

Age: 76, Retired Construction Worker

Mobility limitations from decades of physical labor. Her polling place has no accessible entrance and no curbside voting. If she votes absentee, she needs help—help that SB1 tried to make a felony. SPLC went to court over that law. Evelyn is who they were fighting for.

Multiple Barriers:

T5 ADA failure, T4 no-vehicle, T5 SB1 absentee restriction, T3 route maintenance



Marcus

The Disengaged Young Adult

Russell county

Age: 22, Community College Student

First-time voter. Moved between counties, unsure of his registration status. Class schedule conflicts with Election Day hours. Limited access to digital tools for registration lookup. Russell County was the most competitive county in the 2024 CD-2 race—decided by fewer than 400 straight-party votes. His participation isn't abstract. It's the margin.

Multiple Barriers:

T2 turnout decline, T3 polling place notification gap, T6 registration lookup barrier, T11 first-time voter materials gap

Community Outreach: What Exists, and Where the Gaps Are

Libraries

Public libraries across the 17 counties serve as the primary internet access point for residents without home broadband. They also provide notary services, voter registration assistance, and civic information.

Their distribution relative to population centers is uneven, rural counties with the worst broadband gaps often have the fewest library branches.

Food Pantries & Social Services

Food pantries, community health organizations, and social service agencies are often the most trusted institutions in Black Belt communities. They represent existing infrastructure for civic outreach, and in many cases are already in contact with residents who face the most severe participation barriers.

Educational & Gov't Services

Schools, university extension offices, and community colleges serve as trusted messengers in rural counties. SPLC's educational and policy communication materials are designed to move through exactly these channels, reaching voters where they already engage with public institutions.

If These Are Civic Rights Issues, What Changes?

For Litigation

Building a voting rights case around infrastructure barriers requires documented, measurable evidence at the county and precinct level—distance to polls, road conditions, transit availability, ADA compliance by site. T3, T4, and T5 produced that kind of documentation for Montgomery County and the Black Belt region. It is the kind of record that turns a pattern into a provable claim.

For Advocacy

Broadband infrastructure, road maintenance, and transit funding aren't voting rights issues in the traditional sense. But T6 and T7 project shows they function as voting access conditions. What does SPLC's advocacy portfolio look like if that frame expands?

For Outreach

Libraries, food pantries, and community colleges are already part of how SPLC reaches Black Belt communities. T8, T9, T10, and T11 designed materials to move through those channels—plain-language voter guides, policy summaries, and civic process materials grounded in data from these 17 counties and these communities specifically, not generic voter education but documentation of the actual barriers Black Belt voters face, formatted for the institutions already in contact with them.

Transportation: The Last Mile to the Ballot Box

Getting to the polls is not a simple trip. Here are the factors that make it hard.

Distance to polling location

HIGH

Average distance to polling places: 1.02–1.58 miles by routing method. Only 45.2% of routes are maintained. Rural counties face greater barriers than distance alone suggests.

Vehicle access

HIGH

Dallas County: 15.1% car-free (highest in region). Region-wide, car-free rates range from 5% to 15.1% across the 17 counties.

Public transit availability

HIGH

Five of six lowest-income counties have no fixed-route transit. Bullock County has zero transit service. Demand-response transit (call-ahead scheduling) is the only option in most of the region.

Rideshare coverage

MED

Rideshare services have limited or no coverage in rural Black Belt counties. Not a reliable Election Day option for most residents outside Montgomery.

Road quality & rural access

MED

Road quality score across the region: 54.6/100. Unpaved and poorly maintained roads extend effective travel times beyond what raw distance figures suggest.

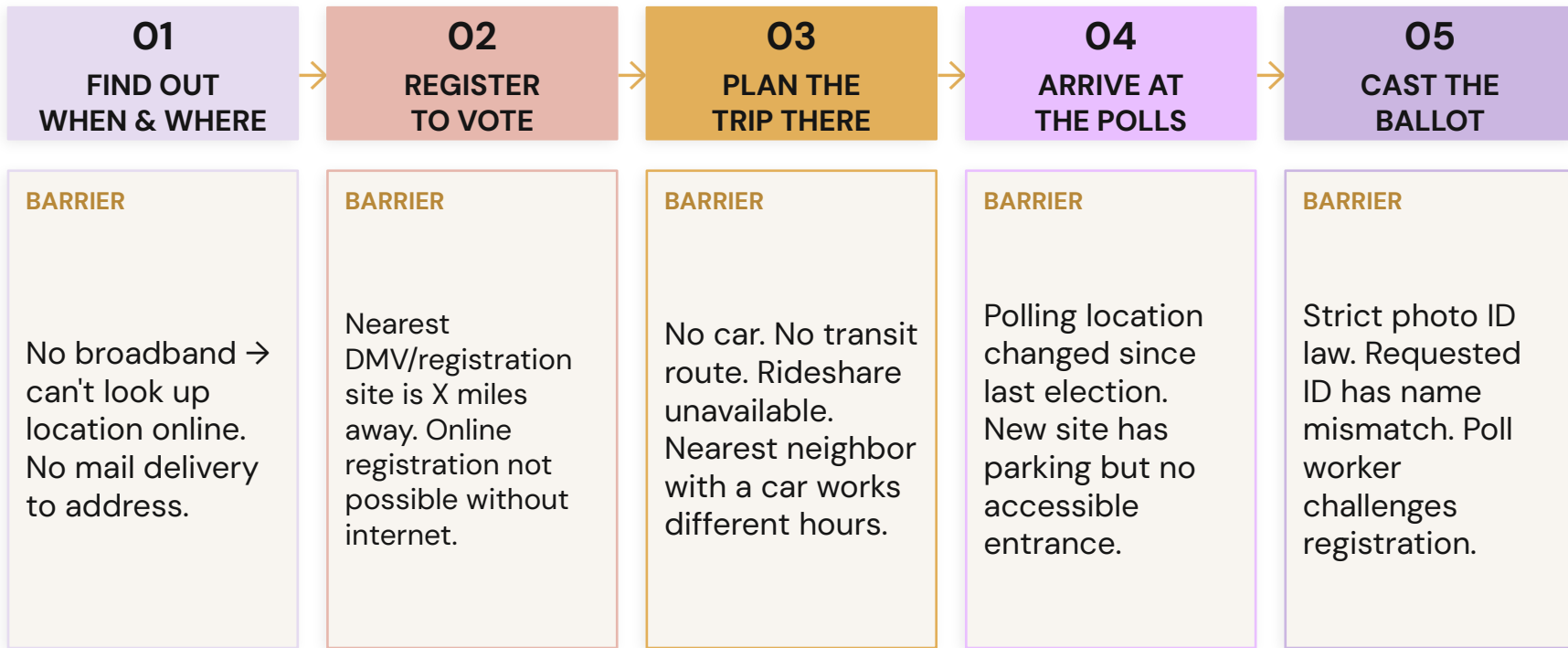
Work schedule constraints

MED

Alabama has no early voting. Polls are open 7am–7pm. Hourly workers, shift workers, and caregivers frequently cannot leave work during those hours without losing pay.

A Voter's Journey: Barriers Along the Way

Walking through the challenges one person faces—drawn from T9 community personas and regional data.



SECTION 05

From Data to Action

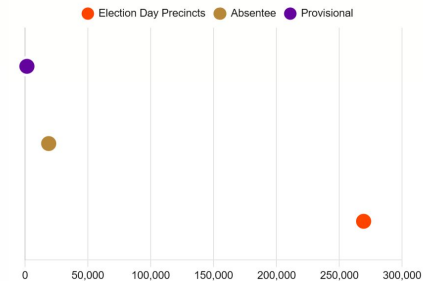
Visualization, policy translation, and community communications—the tools that make this research usable beyond this room

Visualization: How to Read the Data

T8 built a dashboard that makes 13 counties of election data readable in one place—county victory margins, total counted votes, and how votes were cast, without sorting through separate spreadsheets

Voting methods

This chart compares the method of vote across election-day precincts, absentee ballots, and provisional ballots.



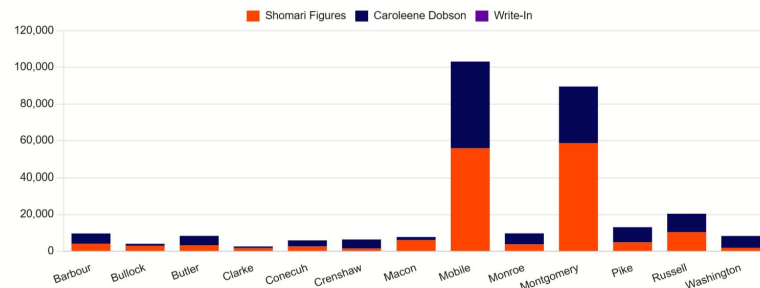
Each dot shows the total votes cast by method, with election-day, absentee, and provisional ballots separated.

Key takeaway: Election Day Precincts is the largest method of vote in the current selection at 93.0%.

[View data table fallback](#)

County vote composition

This stacked chart shows how each county's total vote is split across candidates, giving a broader picture of the race across all selected counties.



Each stacked bar represents one county and shows how much each candidate contributed to that county's total vote.

Key takeaway: This view shows both size and composition, making it easier to compare large counties with smaller ones while still seeing candidate balance within each county.

[View data table fallback](#)

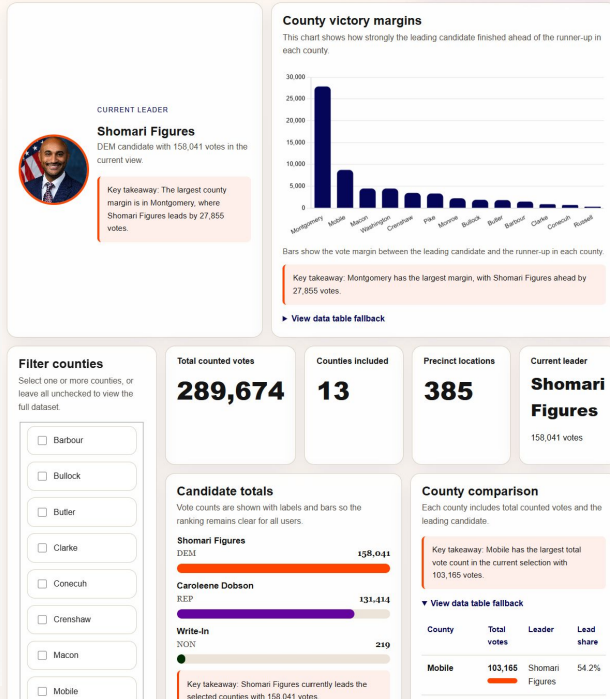
DATA VISUALIZATION PROJECT

BB-VIZ Election Dashboard

A simple, accessible dashboard for exploring 2024 general election results across the counties in our uploaded dataset.

UNITED STATES REPRESENTATIVE, 2ND CONGRESSIONAL DISTRICT

Built with semantic HTML, strong contrast, visible focus states, and chart labels that do not rely on color alone.



How to use these visuals:

The BB-VIZ dashboard lets SPLC compare voting access and election patterns across 13 counties in one place—without sorting through separate CSV files. Key indicators: county victory margins, total counted votes by county, and voting method breakdown (Election Day: 93.0% · Absentee: 6.5% · Provisional: 0.5%).

Use it to identify which counties need closer review for civic infrastructure concerns. [Link to live dashboard](#)

Policy Communication: Translating Data into Advocacy

T10 translated the legal and policy landscape affecting Black Belt voters into plain-language documents designed for policymakers, advocacy partners, and funders—grounded in the findings this project produced

This deliverable enables SPLC to:

Present county-level data on how polling place closures and ID requirements have disproportionately reduced turnout in majority-Black counties—supported by T1, T2, and T3 findings.

Use T4's county-level transit data and T3's distance analysis to establish measurable, documentable transportation barriers—a factual foundation for voting rights litigation.

T10's non-partisan summary document consolidates key federal laws, court decisions, and state policies into a single reference for briefing advocacy partners and funders.

Alabama ranks in the top 3 states nationally for felony disenfranchisement. T10 documents the legal and financial barriers to rights restoration that suppress re-registration among formerly incarcerated residents.

Alabama ranks in the top three states nationally for **felony disenfranchisement**, with approximately **227,000** people currently unable to vote. T10 documents the legal and financial barriers to rights restoration—unclear eligibility rules, outstanding fines, and a reinstatement process that disproportionately affects Black Belt residents—in a format usable for stakeholder briefings.

1. IMPACT OF SHELBY COUNTY v. HOLDER (2013)

Removal of Federal Oversight Led to Stricter Voting Policies



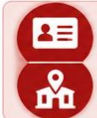
BEFORE 2013

Federal Oversight (Preclearance)
Certain states, including Alabama, had to get federal approval before changing voting laws.



2013 SUPREME COURT DECISION *Shelby County v. Holder*

The Court ruled that the federal preclearance requirement was unconstitutional.



AFTER 2013: POLICY CHANGES IN ALABAMA

- Stricter Voter ID Laws
- Removal of Specific Polling Locations
- No Longer Required to Get Federal Approval for Voting Law Changes



IMPACT

These changes disproportionately affect:

- Low-income voters
- Minority communities

Sources: Brennan Center for Justice, "The Effects of Shelby County v. Holder," 2013.
U.S. Supreme Court, *Shelby County v. Holder*, 570 U.S. 529 (2013).

2. FELONY DISENFRANCHISEMENT IN ALABAMA

A Major Barrier to Voting Rights



227,000+

People are disenfranchised in Alabama due to felony convictions.



TOP 3 IN THE U.S.

for percentage of voting ineligibility due to felony convictions.

KEY BARRIERS TO RESTORING VOTING RIGHTS



LEGAL FINES & FEES

Court costs, fines, and fees create financial barriers that prevent individuals from completing their sentences and restoring rights.



COMPLEX ELIGIBILITY RULES

Unclear and inconsistent rules about who is eligible and how to apply make the process confusing and discouraging.



DIFFICULT RE-REGISTRATION PROCESS

Lack of information, long wait times, and administrative hurdles make it difficult to re-register and vote.

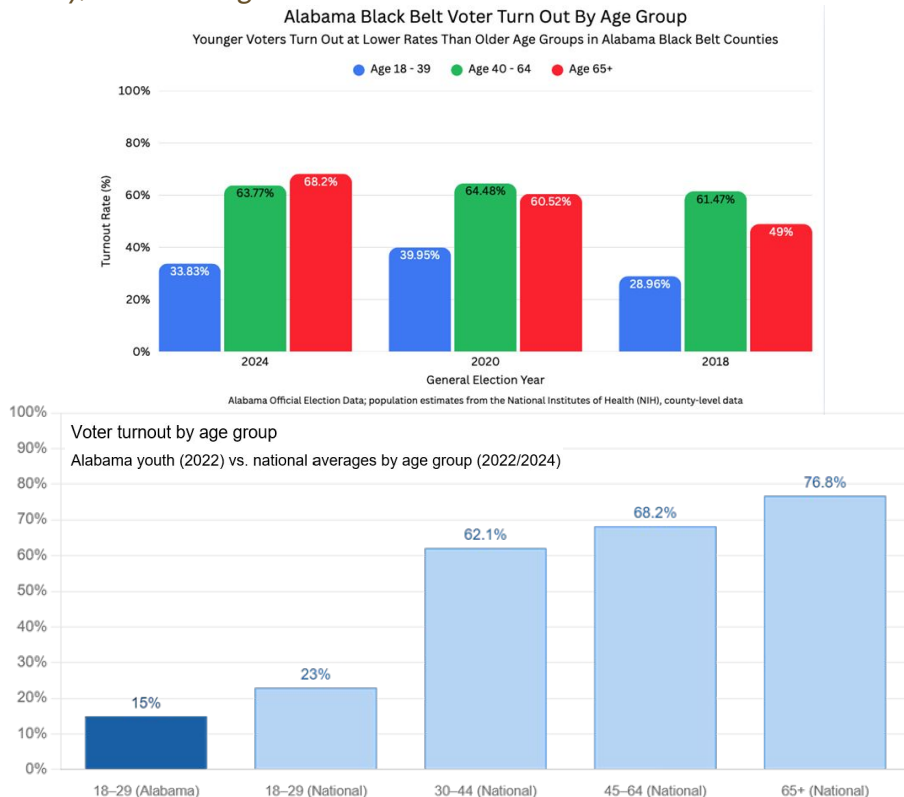


These barriers limit participation, especially in Black Belt communities, and weaken the voices of thousands of Alabamians.

Sources: Britannica.com, "Felony Disenfranchisement"; The Sentencing Project, Locked Out 2022.

The Participation Gap Starts Young

Youth voter turnout in Alabama isn't a 2024 anomaly—it's a structural pattern. Black Belt counties show the same age gradient seen nationally, but starting from a lower baseline.



15%

Alabama youth voter turnout in the 2022 midterms—one of the worst records in the country, and **less than a third** of the 51% national average for voters 45–64 that same year

KEY TAKEAWAY

The age turnout gap in Alabama's Black Belt isn't explained by disengagement—it *reflects a younger population navigating more barriers with less institutional support*. First-time voters, recent movers, students, and hourly workers face the steepest climb. That's the audience T11's tools were built for.

Community & Educational Comms: Getting Information to People

Alabama's **youth voter turnout was 15% in 2022**—one of the worst records in the country. **Voters 65 and older turned out at over 75% nationally in 2024.** T11 built the tools to start closing that gap.

Are you eligible to vote?

To register to vote in Alabama you must:



- Be a United States Citizen
- Reside in Alabama
- Be at least 18 years old
- Have not been convicted of a disqualifying felony (or have rights restored)
- Have not been legally declared "mentally incompetent" by a court

<https://www.vote.org/voter-registration-rules/>

Alabama's youth voter turnout in 2022 was 15%, one of the worst records in the country. Voters 65+ turned out at over 75% nationwide, **a gap of more than 28 percentage points.**

Example social media post from T11's voter engagement campaign targeting 18–29 year olds.

* SPLC-Group 11



Alabama Voter Guide

Empowering voters with essential information

Click one of the buttons below to get started!

Why Should You Vote

First Time Voter?
Start here and follow along!

Voting Registration

Need to register to vote?
Click Here!

Preparing for Election Day

Getting ready to vote?
Click Here!

Special Voting Topics

Want to go deeper in elections?
Click Here!

Voters

Plain-language voting guides, rights cards, and an interactive voter guide designed for mobile devices—built around the barriers Black Belt voters actually face, not generic civic education. First-time voters can navigate the registration and polling process without prior experience.

Community Organizations

Materials formatted for distribution through libraries, food pantries, and social service organizations—the trusted institutions already in contact with the residents most likely to face participation barriers, and most likely to be missed by traditional outreach.

Educators

Social media campaign content and civic education materials for K–12 schools, community colleges, and adult education programs. Framed around accessibility and information gaps, not lack of interest—because the data shows younger voters face structural barriers, not apathy.

SECTION 06

Conclusions & Recommendations

What the Data Show Together: The Regional Picture

Across 17 counties and 11 research teams, the data converge on a clear finding: civic participation barriers in Alabama's Black Belt are not isolated problems—they compound. A resident of Bullock County faces no transit service, a 12.6% car-free household rate, a voter base where nearly half of ballots come from residents 60+, and the fourth-lowest median income in the region. Each factor alone is a barrier. Together, they function as a system.

VOTER TURNOUT

Black voter participation fell in 21 of 24 counties between 2020 and 2024, dropping from 62.8% to 57.2% on average while White participation held at ~68% nearly doubling the racial participation gap.

POLLING ACCESS

Average distance to polls: 1.02–1.58 miles. Only 45.2% of routes are maintained. 28% of block groups have poor or very poor accessibility; with rural areas facing the greatest structural barriers.

TRANSPORTATION

Dallas County: 15.1% of households have no vehicle, the highest in the region, with only call-ahead demand-response transit available. Five of six lowest-income counties have no fixed-route transit. Bullock: zero transit.

ACCESSIBILITY

Only 55% of surveyed polling locations have fully accessible entrances. Smaller sites consistently lack compliant parking and drop-off areas, disproportionately affecting people with mobility impairments.

BROADBAND

Precincts with broadband index scores above 100 mbps showed higher 2024 voter turnout. Where broadband is absent, digital civic processes, registration, absentee ballots, polling lookup, are functionally unavailable.

COMPOSITE RISK

Wilcox County has the highest civic participation risk in the region. Bullock the second highest. Butler has the lowest risk with Montgomery County having the second lowest risk. These rankings synthesize 17 variables across four subindex categories: infrastructure access, demographic factors, geographic isolation, and individual capability.

Where the Evidence Points: Recommended Actions

Each measure captures a different dimension of civic access—the counties that look worst depend on what you're measuring, and the full picture emerges only when the findings are read together.

VOTER TURNOUT

Prioritize Election Day transportation and outreach resources in **Sumter**, **Lowndes**, and **Russell**, where turnout decline and competitive margins overlap.

POLLING ACCESS

Use T3's ArcGIS dashboard to identify specific block groups where walkability scores and vulnerability overlap—first-tier candidates for mobile polling advocacy.

TRANSPORTATION

Deploy Election Day transportation resources in **Dallas** and **Bullock** first. Investigate whether demand-response transit providers can be funded to operate on Election Day without advance scheduling.

ACCESSIBILITY

Use T5's dataset to identify the five lowest-scoring sites for priority in-person verification. Consider a pre-election accessibility certification advocacy push using the DOJ checklist as the standard.

BROADBAND

Overlay T6's broadband map against T2's county-level turnout decline data to identify where digital access gaps and participation drops co-occur—these are the clearest targets for library and community center digital access advocacy.

COMPOSITE RISK

Use T7's index to triage. **Wilcox**, **Bullock**, **Lowndes**, and **Greene** appear at or near the bottom across multiple subindices simultaneously—not just the composite score. These four counties are the clearest candidates for concentrated resource deployment.

Next Steps for SPLC

01 Access the deliverables

Access the deliverables: All datasets, dashboards, maps, personas, policy briefs, and guides are in the [shared Google Drive folder](#).

02 Explore the composite risk map

T7's county-level risk index is the fastest entry point for prioritization. Use it alongside other teams' findings and contextual research for the fullest county-level picture.

03 Connect with the teams

Every team has members available to answer methodology questions. Team contacts are on the next slide

04 Identify your highest-priority use case

Is this litigation support, community outreach, policy advocacy, or funder reporting? The answer determines which deliverables to engage with first.

Thank You — Team Credits

11 teams. One regional story.

T1

Foundation

BB-DIG: Arnav Patel, Asmita Brahme, Bao Nguyen, Margaret Hermanto, Matthew Ritter, Leon Zhang

T2

Voter Turnout

BB-VOTE: Griffin Biddle, Evan Carr, Bryan Cristales Rivas, Benjamin Donkor, Brayden Hull

T3

Polling Access

BB-PAD: Jacy Dickstein, Janice Imuze, Myles Sartor, Jayden Ervin, Mawa Clarke

T4

Transportation

BB-TRAC: Don Brazelton, Oswalt Vasquez, Setareh Mahjoob, Mateen Vafa, Yeongjae Roh

T5

Accessibility

BB-AACS: Samantha An, Jessica Barke, Katherine Delaney, Megan Otchet, Catalina Herrera, Derik Luc

T6

Broadband

BB-BAND: Ronja Markoff, Isa Ansari, Elliott Perez, James Droter, Dominic Balzano

T7

Composite Risk

BB-CPRI: Michelle Akem, Eli Jean, Ethan Schwartzberg, Noah Lee, Vonn Savaya

T8

Visualization

BB-VIZ: Hawareyawe Ketema, Eyoha Henoke, Getnet Workalemahu, Milca Teklezgi, Michael Melaku

T9

Community Context

BB-CCP: Alison Wu, Alejandra Saravia, Kyrene Jamero, Yafet Tedros

T10

Policy Comms

BB-PORT: Zohair Farouk, Ryan Mitchell, Nayab Safdar, Sudenur Yavuz

T11

Community Comms

BB-CPAD: Lakshya Sajal Kumar, Matthew Romalis, Michaela Angela James, Amari Harrington, Uziel Saldivar

Thank you!
Questions & Discussion